CHENNAI - MONDAY - OCTOBER 5, 2026

₹10 • Pages 14 • Volume 33 • Number 276

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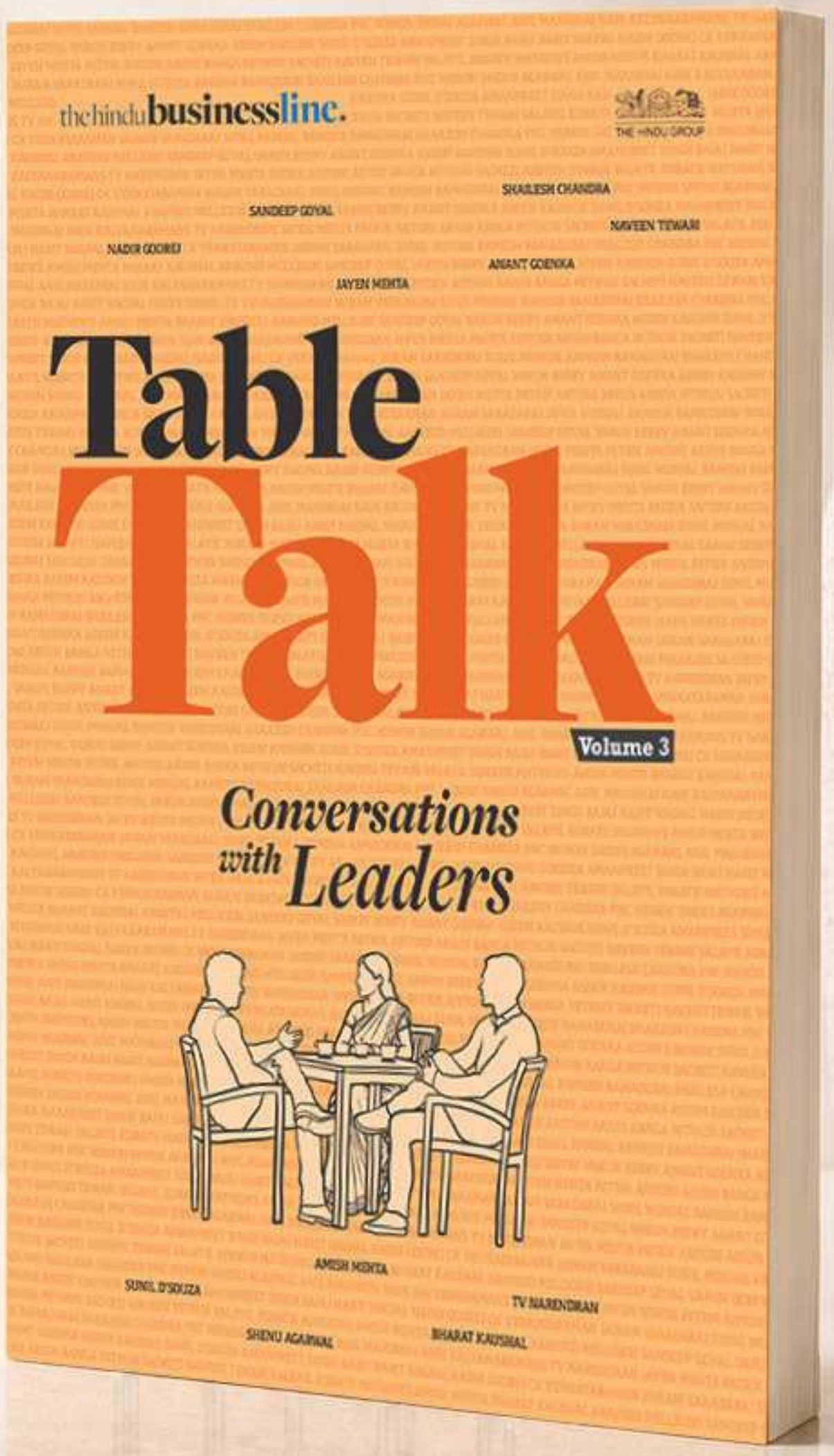
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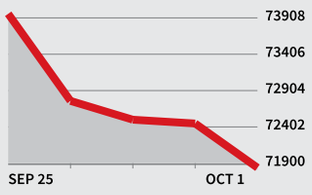
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IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	22421.95	-718.55
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.09	-0.53
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.31	+0.50
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	147545.00	-3959
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	220829.00	-11521



CHANGING TREND.

NSE Chairman Srinivas Injeti and CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan say the focus is now shifting to deepening financialisation **p5**



IN LIMBO.

The Data Protection Board is yet to be set up; norms on the consent manager regime are also awaited **p12**

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Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

MOBILITY SHIFT

OEMs key for automotive transition: JSW Motors



New Delhi: JSW Motors has said that CAFE-III, which kicks in from April next year, would allow it to plan its products, technologies, investments and localisation efforts with greater clarity. Ranjan Nayak, CEO, JSW Motors, said the next phase of India's automotive transition will require original equipment manufacturers to take a broader view of mobility, and it will require alignment across vehicle technology, charging infrastructure, battery manufacturing, renewable power and consumer adoption. **p2**

POWERING UP

Offshore wind farm planned off TN coast

Chennai: India's first offshore wind farm prototype is being planned in the coastal waters off Thoothukudi, with a single 6.25 MW turbine to be installed about 1,650 m from the southern breakwater of the inner harbour. The project, estimated at ₹77 crore, is being tendered by IPRCL. **p4**

RBI seen raising repo rate by 25 basis points this week

***businessline* POLL.** Seven in 10 bank economists expect a neutral policy stance

Ashokamithran T
Mumbai

Bankers expect the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to raise the policy repo rate by 25 basis points (bps) on Wednesday, with a majority also expecting the MPC to deliver a cumulative 50-75 bps rate hike by the end of FY27, according to a poll of bank economists conducted by *businessline*.

Eleven of the 12 chief economists from major public and private sector banks surveyed expect a 25-bps increase in the repo rate, taking it to 5.5 per cent. Only Bank of Baroda's Chief Economist Madan Sabnavis expects the MPC to keep the rates unchanged.

What economists say

Bank	MPC expectation	Stance Forecast
Union Bank of India	25 bps hike	Neutral
Axis Bank	25 bps hike	Neutral
Kotak Mahindra Bank	25 bps hike	Neutral
IDFC First Bank	25 bps hike	Neutral
IndusInd Bank	25 bps hike	Neutral
Barclays	25 bps hike	Neutral
Yes Bank	25 bps hike	Neutral
DBS Bank	25 bps hike	Withdrawal of accommodation
RBL	25 bps hike	Withdrawal of accommodation
Bank of Baroda	hold rates	Hawkish
SBI	25 bps hike	NA
HSBC	25 bps hike	NA

HAWKISH TONE

Seven out of 10 respondents expect the RBI to maintain a neutral policy stance. Two banks, DBS Bank and RBL Bank, anticipate a shift to a "withdrawal of accommodation" stance, while Sabnavis believes that the central bank could adopt a more hawkish tone.

All respondents who forecast a rate hike cited rising inflation expectations, the need to align with global central bank actions, and concerns over imported inflation stemming from elevated crude oil prices as key reasons for their call.

DOMESTIC GROWTH

"We believe that the start of a rate hike cycle is warranted at the current juncture to align with global central banks, address rising inflation risks, and take advantage of strong domestic growth, which provides policy space for a cumulative 75 bps hike," said Kanika Pasricha, Chief Economist at Union Bank of India.

Echoing a similar view, Gaura Sengupta, Chief Economist, IDFC First Bank, said, "We expect a shallow rate-hiking cycle of 75 bps, driven by a rise in domestic inflation."

75 BPS HIKE BY FY27

While most bankers expect the policy stance to remain neutral, six economists forecast that FY27 could end with the repo rate at 6 per cent, implying a cumulative increase of 75 bps from current levels.

"A gradual broadening of price pressures is likely to keep headline inflation above 5 per cent in the second half of FY27, narrowing the real rate buffer and reinforcing the need for a tighter policy bias," said Radhika Rao of DBS Bank.

Apart from higher crude oil prices, managing the rupee's depreciation is also a factor supporting the case for a rate hike, according to Anitha Rangan, Chief Economist at RBL Bank.

FESTIVE SEASON

While Sabnavis expects the MPC to hold rates in October, he believes a 25 bps hike is likely in the December policy review, followed by another 25 bps increase in February.

This would take the terminal repo rate to 5.75 per cent by the end of FY27.

Sabnavis argued that an immediate rate hike may not effectively transmit to deposit rates during the festive season, when spending tends to remain elevated.

"One can wait for some time before increasing rates. By not raising rates now, the bond yields could cool," he said.

GST Law Committee proposes higher prosecution threshold, shorter jail terms

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS



- The threshold is proposed to be increased to ₹10 crore from ₹5 crore
- The plan is to lower maximum imprisonment for certain offences
- Another proposed change is to give courts greater discretion in determining punishment

The GST Council is likely to consider a set of changes to the criminal provisions of the indirect tax law, including raising the monetary threshold for prosecution, reducing the maximum imprisonment for some offences and giving the courts greater discretion in deciding between imprisonment and fines, officials told *businessline*.

The proposals, which have been deliberated upon by the GST Council's Law Committee, will be placed before the Council at its October 7 meeting. While there is broad agreement on revising the prosecution and punishment provisions, the committee could not reach a consensus on whether the power to arrest under the GST law should be retained.

"There was consensus on revising the threshold for prosecution, imprisonment and judicial discretion in awarding punishments. However, there were different views on removing provisions related to arrest, so it has been left to the GST Council to take a final call," an official said.

LEGAL REVIEW

The Law Committee, comprising officials from the Centre and States and UTs with legislatures, examines legal provisions under GST and recommends statutory amendments and clarifications to the Council.

One of the key recommendations is to raise the monetary threshold for prosecution. The threshold, which was last revised in 2017, is proposed to be increased to ₹10 crore from the existing ₹5 crore.

"With the growth of the economy, there is need for upward revision in the threshold, in line with the principles highlighting the periodic review of criminal provisions," the official said.

The committee also proposed lowering the maximum imprisonment for some offences. For tax evasion in the ₹5-10 crore range, the maximum sentence is proposed to be reduced to two years from three now.

Another proposed change is to give courts greater discretion in determining punishment. Under the current framework, offences can attract imprisonment along with a fine, but there is a limited scope for the courts to choose between imprisonment, a fine or both, depending on the gravity of the offence.

The official said, "There is no judicial discretion for punishment to either award imprisonment or fine or both based on the severity or gradation of the offence."

The proposal would, therefore, allow the courts to prescribe imprisonment or a fine, or both, taking into account the nature and severity of the offence.

POWER TO ARREST

The more contentious issue is the GST authorities' power to arrest. According to a second official, the Law Committee did not reach an agreement on removing the provision altogether.

Due to divergent views, the Committee could not arrive at a consensus, and the matter has, therefore, been left to the Council.



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QUICKLY.

Deputy ECs to visit 5 States ahead of polls

New Delhi: Election Commission officials, led by Deputy Election Commissioners, will start visiting the five poll-bound States from this week to oversee election preparedness at the field level. Functionaries said this week the team will visit Goa, followed by Uttarakhand, Punjab and Manipur in the coming weeks. There is no word yet on when they will visit Uttar Pradesh. Usually, the "full Commission", comprising the Chief Election Commissioner and fellow Commissioners, visits poll-bound States ahead of elections. PTI

India, Canada to begin 5th pact talks on October 5

New Delhi: The chief negotiators of India and Canada will begin the fifth round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement in Ottawa from October 5, an official said. The five-day talks may end on October 9. The negotiations are important as Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to visit Canada around December this year, as Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney has said. PTI

'CAFE-III is a key roadmap for greener mobility'

MOBILITY SHIFT. India's automotive transition requires OEMs to align vehicle technology, charging, batteries, renewable power and consumer adoption

bl.interview

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

JSW Motors has said that CAFE-III, which kicks in from April next, would allow it to plan its products, technologies, investments and localisation efforts with greater clarity.

Ranjan Nayak, Chief Executive Officer, JSW Motors, said that the next phase of India's automotive transition will require original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) to take a broader view of mobility, and it will require alignment across vehicle technology, charging infrastructure, battery manufacturing, renewable power and consumer adoption.

Edited excerpts:

In what ways will the CAFE-III fuel efficiency guidelines help new entrants like JSW Motors plan their product strategy?
CAFE-III provides greater regulatory certainty, which is important for companies like JSW Motors as we build our product and technology roadmap for the coming years.

The three plus two-year compliance block structure gives companies greater flexibility to align their sales and powertrain strategies with the stipulated CAFE targets.

The recognition of multiple electrified powertrains also gives us greater clarity on where to focus investments and technology development.

For JSW Motors, this is particularly relevant as we are already working towards launching clean technologies across New Energy Vehicles (NEVs).

The framework allows us to plan our products, technologies, investments and localisation efforts with greater clarity.

> The next phase of India's automotive transition will require OEMs to take a broader view of mobility
>
> **RANJAN NAYAK**
> CEO, JSW Motors



What specific technologies would you leverage to maximise regulatory benefits under these norms?
Our approach is centred on a portfolio of NEVs, including Range-Extended Electric Vehicles (REEVs) and Plug-in Hybrid Electric Vehicles (PHEVs). Each technology addresses a different consumer need and can play a role in India's transition towards cleaner mobility. NEVs are particularly suited to consumers with convenient access to charging.

REEVs use electric motors for propulsion, while a range-extending engine generates electricity when required, offering an alternative for consumers concerned about charging access and long-distance travel.

PHEVs combine external charging and electric driving capability with an internal-combustion engine, providing flexibility for both urban and intercity use.

We particularly welcome the higher volume derogation factor for NEVs and REEVs, followed by PHEVs and eligible strong hybrids, as this recognises the greater contribution of NEVs while allowing different electrified powertrains to contribute to the transition.

What would be your localisation levels for these technologies?
Our objective is to progressively build a more localised new energy vehicle ecosystem in line with the broader goals of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat.

As battery manufacturing scales, greater localisation across the electric mobility value chain can strengthen domestic supply chains and reduce import dependence for critical technologies over time. CAFE-III further strengthens the case for such investments across the industry.

The government has laid out the path now, so what should original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) do to meet carbon neutrality while keeping affordability for customers in mind?

The next phase of India's automotive transition will require OEMs to take a broader view of mobility.

It will require alignment across vehicle technology, charging infrastructure, battery manufacturing, renewable power and consumer adoption.

For OEMs, the focus should be on bringing cleaner and increasingly efficient technologies to consumers while recognising that different powertrains address different consumer needs.

Affordability and adoption will ultimately depend on how effectively the industry can develop and localise these technologies and make them relevant for Indian consumers.

CAFE-III provides the regulatory foundation for this transition. The industry now needs to translate that framework into sustained investment and greater consumer adoption of cleaner mobility technologies.

Why is the NEV approach important for India's mobility transition?
Greater adoption of NEV technologies can create demand for domestic battery manufacturing, components, power electronics and associated technologies.

India has already taken steps in this direction through the Production Linked Incentive scheme for Advanced Chemistry Cells.

This creates an opportunity for India to build capabilities across cells, packs, materials and other components, strengthen domestic supply chains and support a more self-reliant mobility ecosystem.

How important is the provision for pooling and trading of CAFE compliance credits?
The provision provides manufacturers with greater flexibility in meeting CAFE targets as manufacturers can exchange credits and also create an economic incentive for companies investing in cleaner and more efficient technologies. For a company such as JSW Motors, this provides another element of flexibility as we build our product and powertrain strategy.

Can CAFE-III help India reduce its dependence on imported fossil fuels?
Reducing petrol and diesel consumption in road transport has implications beyond emissions.

Greater electrification of passenger mobility can support cleaner mobility while strengthening India's energy security and reducing dependence on imported fossil fuels.

What will be critical to making this transition successful?
The transition will require continued collaboration and dialogue between policymakers and auto and technology companies. CAFE-III provides an important regulatory foundation, but the objective should be to translate the framework into sustained investment, innovation, localisation and greater consumer adoption of cleaner mobility technologies.

Saint-Gobain plans ₹11,000 crore India push over the next 5 years

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

Sreedhar N, Saint-Gobain's first non-French global CFO before taking charge of its Asia-Pacific and India business, doesn't want to sell Indian builders just another construction product.

He wants to sell them a quieter, cooler, and more energy-efficient building and believes the French group now has enough pieces of that building to do it.

"I don't come here to sell you a product," said Sreedhar, now Saint-Gobain's Senior Vice-President and CEO for Asia-Pacific and India. "I will reduce the energy bill and reduce the noise," he said, adding that he has a complete solution.

Now he is putting money behind that proposition. Saint-Gobain plans to invest ₹11,000 crore in India over the next five years, and Sreedhar is scouting for acquisitions as he pushes beyond the glass business that established the group in India into faster-growing segments such as construction chemicals and insulation.

"I am willing to acquire anything meaningful for our organisation," he told *businessline*.



Sreedhar N, Senior V-P and CEO for Asia-Pacific and India, Saint-Gobain

SHARP ACCELERATION
The investment represents a sharp acceleration. Saint-Gobain invested ₹9,900 crore in India over the previous decade. The new programme would lift its average annual investment from about ₹990 crore to ₹2,200 crore, an increase of roughly 122 per cent.

India already ranks among Saint-Gobain's top five markets by profitability and is its fastest-growing country, Sreedhar said.

The group's latest shareholder disclosures put India sales at €1.7 billion in 2025, with an EBITDA margin above 20 per cent. Chairman and CEO Benoit Bazin has outlined an ambition to triple the size of the Indian business over the coming decade.

BUYING GROWTH
Sreedhar knows the acquisition playbook. As global CFO, he was part of a transformation that reshaped about 40 per cent of Saint-Gobain's portfolio.

Its $1.025-billion acquisition of Fosroc, completed in February 2025, brought 20 manufacturing plants and a significant Indian construction chemicals business. Alongside Chryso, GCP, and OVNIVER, it helped build a €6.5-billion global construction chemicals platform.

For Sreedhar, deals are about more than price. Preparation, speed, and giving a seller certainty that a transaction will close are critical, followed by locally driven integration. "Having local CEOs across our operations has done the magic for us," adds Sreedhar.

The opportunity is also about penetration. He expects insulation and construction chemicals to grow particularly quickly in India, while gypsum board could open up another market as its use spreads from commercial buildings into homes.

INDIAN MARKET
Saint-Gobain already has 82 plants in India. Its Chennai innovation hub has 300 scientists developing products and solutions specifically for the Indian market, and Sreedhar said the team has generated 275 patents.

In Tamil Nadu, the group has committed ₹5,400 crore, comprising an initial ₹3,400 crore followed by another ₹2,000 crore, across projects in the State. The additional ₹2,000 crore is a longer-term commitment over the coming decade.

India is also becoming a base for regional markets. Stone wool made here has been qualified for Australia, while higher-value glass is supplied to Australia, Southeast Asia, and the Middle East.

Yet Sreedhar's ambition ultimately goes beyond factories, acquisitions, or exports. He wants lighter building materials to displace some of the bricks, cement, and other heavy materials that dominate Indian construction.

"I would like to see if I can completely replace sand, cement, and brick. That would be my dream," he said. "Can I do it? I think it's feasible."

For India, he conceded, that remains "a long, long way" off. "But sometimes you need to have a dream," Sreedhar said, adding that he is here "to make some beginning".

SC to hear today pleas for suspension of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, undoing 'unauthorised' actions

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas seeking the suspension of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and challenging the manner in which the poll panel led by him took decisions, allegedly without the approval of two Election Commissioners.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana is scheduled to hear the pleas filed by Rakesh Kumar Singh and advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi, who have also challenged the decisions, guidelines and software changes allegedly made by Kumar without the concurrence of his two colleagues.

The PIL, filed by Patna resident Rakesh Kumar Singh, had urged the top court to determine whether Kumar had been individually exercising powers that legally belong to the Election Commission (EC) as a whole and, if so, to declare those actions as unauthorised and take appropriate legal action.

KUMAR'S SUSPENSION
It also demanded the suspension of Kumar pending the final hearing of the petition to preserve the "multi-member character of the Election Commission".

The plea comes against the backdrop of a newspaper report that claimed that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions and orders on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls that they said were issued without their knowledge or recommendation.



Gyanesh Kumar, Chief Election Commissioner

Under fire, the EC said differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberations in any institution, and all its orders carry full legal sanction and follow established statutory procedures. The plea also sought initiation of criminal proceedings against the CEC and other officials for breach of official duty.

"Divested of any statutory or constitutional immunity, the Chief Election Commissioner remains directly accountable under the law — subject to police investigation, evidence gathering and regular trial proceedings as an ordinary accused," the plea stated.

According to the petition, the two Election Commissioners other than Kumar objected to the change and asserted that the prescribed form could not be altered without following the statutory procedure.

Concerns over the handling of electoral roll revisions in Goa and West Bengal were also mentioned in the plea, which alleged that the software lacked the feature to restore 97 eligible electors in Goa despite directions for their verification.

Aviation Ministry to discuss Mumbai airport issues tomorrow

Press Trust of India
New Delhi/Mumbai

The Civil Aviation Ministry has convened a meeting of airlines and Adani Airport's representatives on Tuesday to discuss the proposed partial shifting of international flights from Mumbai airport to Navi Mumbai airport, according to sources.

With Mumbai airport's Terminal 1 renovation set to start in January 2027, airlines have been asked to stop one-third of their international operations from October 25 or shift them to Navi Mumbai airport.

Sources said representatives of airlines, including IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet, and Adani Airports, are expected to attend the meet, chaired by Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha.

'AP govt to implement 100% housing programme by 2029'

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The NDA government in Andhra Pradesh will achieve 100 per cent housing in the State, according to Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

Speaking after laying the foundation stone along with Union Minister for Rural Development Shivraj Singh Chouhan for the construction of 3 lakh houses across the State under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) 2.0 at Burripalem in the Tenali constituency on Sunday, he said the Centre had initially sanctioned only 75,000 houses to Andhra Pradesh under the regular quota.

However, following a special request, the Centre had sanctioned 3 lakh houses.

Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan had agreed to sanction another 3 lakh houses as soon as the current batch was completed and an additional 3 lakh houses next year, taking the total allocation to 9 lakh houses, he added.

QUALITY HOUSES
Naidu added that the present government had renewed its commitment to constructing quality houses for the poor. As part of this initiative, 3D concrete printing technology would be introduced on a pilot basis at Burripalem.



WELFARE PUSH. AP Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan in Burripalem, Tenali, after laying the foundation for three lakh houses under PMAY-G 2.0

Houses built using this technology were expected to maintain indoor temperatures at least 8 degrees Celsius lower than the outside temperature, providing greater comfort to residents

After successful completion of 3D technology houses, construction of 5000 houses will be taken up with the same technology to make Andhra Pradesh a role model in the 3D technology housing programme, he said.

CENTRE'S SUPPORT
Addressing the meeting, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said Andhra Pradesh was emerging as one of the leading States in the country.

Highlighting the support extended to farmers, Chouhan said the Centre was providing ₹6,000 annually to each eligible farmer under the PM-KISAN scheme, while the Andhra Pradesh government was adding another ₹14,000 under Annadata Sukhibhava, taking the total annual assistance to ₹20,000.

Karnataka gig unions seek faster welfare implementation

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Karnataka's gig worker welfare framework faces a crucial implementation test, with worker unions pushing the State to move from collecting welfare contributions to delivering social security benefits.

The Indian Federation of App-based Transport Workers and the Karnataka App-based Workers Union, in a letter dated October 1 to the Chief Executive Officer and Additional Labour Commissioner of the Karnataka Platform-Based Gig Workers Welfare Board, sought an urgent meeting of the Board to finalise and implement welfare schemes for platform workers.

The unions have sought five broad categories of benefits — universal health and accident insurance, income and maternity support, scholarships for workers' children, an emergency distress fund, and portable pension and social-security benefits.

WELFARE FEE
The demand comes after Karnataka operationalised its gig worker welfare fee mechanism in February 2026. Under the notification, platforms are required to pay a 1 per cent welfare fee on payouts, subject to transaction-level caps depending on the category of service.

The proceeds are intended to finance social security measures under the Karnataka Platform Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act, 2025.

Port unions seek protection for Indian seafarers

Our Bureau
Kochi

The Water Transport Workers Federation of India has expressed serious concern over the risks faced by Indian seafarers working aboard vessels navigating war-affected and conflict-prone maritime routes, including the Strait of Hormuz, the Red Sea and the Black Sea.

In a resolution adopted at its 11th National Conference in Chennai, the Federation urged the Centre to take expeditious and effective measures to ensure the safety and security of Indian seafarers. It called for appropriate diplomatic interventions, strengthened maritime security measures and effective emergency-response mechanisms in coordination with the International Maritime Organization and the governments concerned.

SAFETY CONCERNS
The Federation pointed out that thousands of Indian seafarers play an important role in the international maritime economy and said their safety and security should not be treated merely as a commercial responsibility of shipping companies.

It also called for adequate compensation and social security protection for seafarers and their families in cases of death, injury, disappearance or other serious consequences arising from war or armed conflict while on duty.

T Narendra Rao, General Secretary of the Federation, called upon the government to establish an effective mechanism for providing immediate assistance, compensation and rehabilitation



to affected seafarers and their families. Families facing extreme distress should not be forced to undergo prolonged procedures to obtain relief and compensation.

The conference also urged the Centre to halt what it described as the systematic privatisation of major ports through corporatisation and outsourcing and demanded immediate measures to safeguard the public character of India's port sector.

It strongly opposed the policy of investing large amounts of public money, including surplus funds generated by major ports, in new port infrastructure projects such as Galathea Bay and Vadhavan and subsequently transferring the developed infrastructure and its operations to private entities through public-private partnership or build-operate-transfer arrangements.

It also opposed, what it described, as a series of policy initiatives aimed at gradually weakening public ownership and management of major ports and rejected the landlord model for major ports.

The conference also observed that corporatisation, growing dependence on private operators and increased outsourcing of port activities were adversely affecting the interests of workers and the country's long-term strategic interests.

QNu Labs takes quantum security beyond fibre links

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Deep-tech cybersecurity company QNu Labs has demonstrated its first 5.56-km free-space Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) link, developed in collaboration with BISAG-N and IIT Gandhinagar, marking a step towards quantum-secure communication beyond conventional fibre networks and potentially satellite-based links.

Unlike QKD systems that operate over optical fibre, the demonstration transmitted quantum keys through free space between two locations. QNu Labs used a specialised Pointing, Acquisition and Tracking system to maintain precise laser alignment between the two endpoints, enabling photons to travel directly through the atmosphere.

The free-space capability is significant for applications where laying or accessing dedicated optical fibre is difficult, including long-distance and potentially satellite-based communication.

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Next-gen GST and India's growth through rate rationalisation

POLICY PUSH. GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform

Nirmala Sitharaman


Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

India's ambition to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin. Over the past 12 years, our government has worked to create those conditions. GST's introduction in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation. Next-gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and States.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, next-gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: To reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate changes took effect on September 22, 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly.

Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty. The States have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the Council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment. GST's progress rests on this willingness to pursue a shared national purpose while respecting each government's responsibilities.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew by 25.8 per cent over the corresponding period a year earlier. A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.

That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during April–September 2026, up 11.6 per cent over the corresponding period last year. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15 per cent. Net collections, after refunds, also grew by 10.4 per cent over the half-year. Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

BUSINESS POTENTIAL

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major States. In an economy as diverse as India's, this spread is significant. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more businesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from the demand, investment and employment that follow. Reported sales to consumers (B2C) also rose by 26.7 per cent in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: The purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in tier-2 and -3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST's common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across Central and State jurisdictions stood at approximately 1.71 crore at the end of August, up nearly 15 per cent from a year ago. For the April–July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6 per cent higher than for the same periods last year. These improvements place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: Regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

INPUT TAX CREDIT

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies. This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit.

For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one. Refunds are equally relevant. Approximately ₹1.8 lakh crore was refunded during April–September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence.

The taxpayer's experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance. The States also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16 per cent during April–September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their aspirations. The gains can, therefore, reinforce one another: Household relief supports demand, enterprise strengthens economic activity, and public revenues help sustain development.

The experience also points to the work ahead. A growing system must remain attentive to the costs it imposes on smaller participants. Their time and resources are limited. Each improvement in filing, credit or refunds should allow more of those resources to be devoted to running and expanding a business.

The proposals before the Council on October 7 have been developed through sustained work with the States. They address registration, returns, refunds, disputes and improved flow of input tax credit, with the aim of reducing the time and cost of compliance. Taxpayer experience must continue to guide implementation.

GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. The same commitment to clarity, certainty and respect for the taxpayer guides our work on direct taxes.

A dependable tax system enables enterprises to plan beyond their immediate obligations and invest in opportunities that take time to mature. Giving them that confidence, wherever they operate, helps build the economic strength of a Viksit Bharat as envisioned by the Prime Minister.

The author is Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

India, Chile struggle to clear critical mineral hurdle in CEPA talks

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



India is continuing to push Chile for "something substantive" in terms of commitments on critical mineral supplies, including copper and lithium, as the two countries seek to conclude negotiations on a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) by the year-end, sources said.

Chile is the world's largest producer of mined copper and one of the world's leading lithium producers. Preferential access is important for India as it seeks to diversify supplies of minerals needed for electronics manufacturing, electric vehicles, renewable energy and other industrial applications.

SUPPLY CHAINS

Despite agreeing to a separate chapter on critical minerals in the CEPA, Chile is seeking to focus on cooperation to secure supply chains and exports of value-added products rather than committing to preferential access to raw materials.

India, however, wants at least some preferential treatment in accessing critical minerals, making the issue a persistent sticking point in the negotiations, sources said.

"Some of the preferences recently sought by India for securing supplies have been mostly rejected by Chile on the grounds that they were not possible under its existing laws," a source said.

New Delhi sees critical minerals as an important balancing factor in the proposed pact, particularly as it is opening up its large domestic market to Chile.

"We have given them our strong ask. We are giving the Chileans access to such a big market. In return, we are hardly getting any market. So, at least they must give us something substantive in critical minerals," the source said.

COMMERCIAL TIES

The critical minerals discussions also come amid growing commercial interest between the two countries.

In November 2025, Chilean state-owned miner Codelco and Kutch Copper, a subsidiary of Adani Enterprises, signed an agreement to explore three copper projects in Chile, including possible joint development.

Chile is India's fifth-largest trading partner in the Latin American and Caribbean region.

In 2025, India's exports to Chile were valued at $1.41 billion, up from $1.24 billion the previous year, while imports from Chile rose sharply to $3.97 billion from $2.59 billion, mainly due to higher gold imports, according to government figures.

Striking trade deals with Latin American countries is an important part of India's trade diversification strategy, with the urgency rising as the US tariffs hit exports.

India and Chile signed a preferential trade agreement in 2006, which was expanded in 2017. India offered concessions on 1,031 tariff lines to Chile, while Chile offered concessions on 1,798 Indian tariff lines. The CEPA under negotiation is expected to broaden the scope of the existing agreement to cover goods, critical minerals, services, digital services, MSMEs and investment.

India's exports to Chile comprise automobiles, pharmaceuticals, electrical machinery and equipment, textiles, chemicals, agricultural products, and iron and steel products. Chile's exports to India comprise mainly bulk minerals and ores, including copper concentrate, molybdenum, iodine and gold, as well as inorganic chemicals and agricultural products.

TODAY'S PICK.

Schneider Electric Infrastructure (₹1,275.65): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The Schneider Electric Infrastructure stock has been consolidating in a narrow range of ₹1,160-1,250 over the past month. Last week, it broke out above resistance at ₹1,250, indicating that bulls are gaining traction. The price is now above both the 21- and 50-day moving averages. The outlook has turned positive, and we expect the scrip to gain more from here. The nearest resistance is at ₹1,430. But we expect the stock to surpass this level and appreciate to ₹1,500 over the medium term.

Therefore, we suggest buying the stock now at ₹1,275 and accumulating on the price dips to ₹1,235. Place a stop-loss at ₹1,120. When the stock rises to ₹1,430 and ₹1,475, revise the stop-loss to ₹1,330 and ₹1,425, respectively. Book profits at ₹1,500.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

India's resilience not accidental but outcome of broad, mutually reinforcing reforms: Das

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi


Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary-2 to the PM

Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary-2 to the Prime Minister, on Sunday said India's resilience is not accidental; rather, it is the outcome of broad and mutually reinforcing reforms. He highlighted five major areas that will see significantly greater activity in the journey to Viksit Bharat by 2047.

Das was speaking on the theme 'Resurgent India: Lessons for Emerging Markets' at the Kautilya Economic Conclave. According to him, Kautilya had emphasised that a ruler's foremost responsibility was to anticipate risks, safeguard the state against internal and external threats, and establish institutions capable of preventing and mitigating calamities. "A distinguishing feature of India's development journey in the last 12 years has been the gradual creation of governance foundations before crises emerged," he said.

Further, many of the reforms undertaken over the past decade were not designed as one-off measures, but as strategic buffers to enable the economy to absorb disruptions and recover rapidly. The former Governor of the RBI especially mentioned flexible inflation targeting, introduction of GST, the big push for digital payments and the banking reforms, among other initiatives, taken by the government which helped to overcome crises. "India's resilience is not accidental; it is the outcome of broad and mutually reinforcing reforms," he said.

KEY AREAS

The government has set a target of 2047, the year of 100 years of independence, to achieve 'Viksit Bharat' (Developed Nation). According to Das, the journey to becoming a developed nation will see significantly enhanced activities in five areas.

The first one is in harnessing the artificial intelligence (AI) revolution. According to him, India's AI strategy rests on two complementary pillars. "First, building sovereign AI capabilities through investments in indigenous foundation models, high-performance computing infrastructure, semiconductor development and a robust innovation ecosystem. And second, India is pursuing the vision of 'AI for All'," he said.

The second area is about deepening India's financial sector. Das emphasised that the next phase of growth will require strengthening of long-term finance and patient capital.

"This underscores the need to further deepen corporate bond markets, pension and insurance funds, municipal finance, innovative infrastructure-financing, and a market for green and transition finance," Das said.

The third area is related to promoting strategic *atmanirbharta*.

"*Atmanirbharta* (self-reliance) does not imply isolation. Rather, it stands for building stronger domestic capabilities while remaining integrated with the global markets and concluding more free trade agreements (FTAs)," he said.

The fourth area is about 'sustainable development and climate leadership'. Here the next phase of growth will be driven by initiatives such as the National Green Hydrogen Mission, electric mobility, energy-efficient infrastructure, sustainable agriculture, and circular economy practices.

And the fifth area talks about 'Investing in Human Capital.'

"Over the last 12 years, the number of universities has increased from fewer than 350 to nearly 1,000 and medical colleges from fewer than 400 to around 850. The next stage of development will enhance emphasis on learning 19 outcomes, healthcare delivery, preventive care, research and workforce skills," he said.

LONG-TERM GROWTH

According to Das, Kautilya explained long ago which is preferable — an immediate small gain or a large gain in the future? A large gain in the future is preferable if it is like a seed yielding fruit in the future. "India's strategy is no longer to simply grow rapidly; it is to grow sustainably and resiliently over the long-term," Das said.

Govt raises deepwater gas price ceiling to $9.89 per MMBtu

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government has raised the ceiling price for natural gas produced from difficult fields, such as the KG-D6 block of Reliance Industries and BP, to $9.89 per million British thermal units (MMBtu) for the six months beginning October 1, from $8.9 previously, while keeping the ceiling for gas produced from the legacy fields of state-run ONGC and Oil India Ltd (OIL) at $7 per MMBtu.

The new ceiling for gas from deepwater, ultra-deepwater and high-pressure, high-temperature discoveries is applicable for the period October 1, 2026, to March 31, 2027, according to a notification by the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell of the Oil Ministry.

Gas produced from such difficult areas enjoys marketing and pricing freedom under the government's policy, but is subject to a government-notified ceiling.

GOVT NOTIFICATION

The higher ceiling could provide some relief to producers developing India's more technically challenging offshore gas resources, where production costs are higher than those from mature onshore and legacy fields. For gas produced by ONGC and OIL from their nomination fields, the government has notified an APM price of $11.22 per MMBtu for October, but the actual price remains capped at $7 per MMBtu, according to the PPAC. The APM gas price applies to gas produced from the legacy fields of state-owned ONGC and OIL and is used by priority sectors, including city gas distribution, fertilizer and power.

For gas produced from the new wells of ONGC and OIL in their nomination blocks, the government allows a 10 per cent premium over the prevailing APM gas price, subject to the applicable ceiling. With the APM price for October capped at $7 per MMBtu, the effective price for new-well gas would be up to $7.7 per MMBtu.

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QUICKLY.

SAIL, NMDC told to explore assets abroad



New Delhi: The Steel Ministry has asked its undertakings, SAIL and NMDC, to explore mineral assets abroad to help secure long-term raw material requirements and support input costs, an official said. The move will help secure future requirements and reduce costs, the official added. PTI

OPEC+ to keep oil output targets steady in Nov

Major OPEC+ nations agreed to keep oil production quotas unchanged next month, as the conflict in the Middle East continues to shutter swaths of the group's output. A sub-group of seven countries, led by Saudi Arabia and Russia, will keep targets steady in November, the coalition said in a statement following a monthly video conference on Sunday. It's in line with their existing production roadmap. OPEC+ had already signalled that it would pause production quota hikes through the end of this year. BLOOMBERG

India's first offshore wind farm prototype planned off TN coast

POWERING UP. The ₹77 crore project in coastal waters off Thoothukudi is being tendered by IPRCL

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



HARNESSING WIND. The contract covers the design, procurement, construction, installation, testing and commissioning of the turbine, and two years of operation and maintenance REUTERS

For decades, Tamil Nadu has been one of India's biggest wind power hubs, with turbines spread across its plains and mountain passes. Now, the State is preparing to take the industry into a new frontier — the sea.

India's first offshore wind farm prototype is being planned in the coastal waters off Thoothukudi, with a single 6.25 MW turbine to be installed about 1,650 m from the southern breakwater of the inner harbour.

The project, estimated at ₹77 crore, is being tendered by the Indian Port Rail & Ropeway Corporation Ltd (IPRCL).

The contract covers the design, procurement, construction, installation, testing and commissioning of the offshore wind turbine, followed by two years of operation and maintenance.

The power generated will be evacuated to the State grid. Energy meters installed onshore will record the export of power to the grid and import from the grid in accordance with Tangedco/Tantransco norms, the document said.

"India's first offshore wind turbine marks the point where offshore moves from policy intent to something the industry can see, test and learn from," said Srivatsan Iyer, Global CEO, Hero Future Energies.

He said the turbine would generate operating experience on wind-resource performance, installation and vessel logistics, port and local supply-chain mobilisation, and evacuation of electricity from the sea.

FOUNDATION

According to the tender document, the prototype is intended to establish experience in engineering, marine logistics, grid connectivity and operations — capabilities that would be required for deploying offshore wind at scale.

It is also expected to provide a foundation for future largescale offshore wind projects along India's coastline.

The choice of the Thoothukudi coast is significant. The site combines favourable offshore wind conditions with an established port ecosystem and maritime logistics infrastructure, potentially allowing the project to test not only the turbine but also the wider ecosystem needed to install and operate machines at sea.

DV Giri, an industry expert, said a 6.25 MW turbine is relatively small for offshore wind, where turbines of more than 10 MW are increasingly common. The government, he argued, should instead consider a 1 GW pilot project and involve ONGC, given its experience in deep-water operations.

WIND PROJECTS

According to the Global Wind Energy Council, the average turbine installed in offshore wind projects in 2025 was of 10.3 MW.

Economics remains another challenge. Offshore projects involve substantially higher installation, vessel and marine-infrastructure costs than onshore wind, raising questions over whether the resulting tariff can support financially viable projects without policy support.

India already has a substantial wind power base. Government data put the country's installed wind energy capacity at 57,443 MW as of June 30, 2026. Tamil Nadu is a leading State in India's renewable energy sector with over 10,734 MW.

Everest Food told to recall select batches of cumin powder

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



The food analyst's report found pesticide residues of Azoxystrobin and Thiamethoxam at levels exceeding the prescribed maximum limits

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has directed Everest Food Products to recall some batches of its pre-packed cumin powder from the market after sample tests found it unsafe for consumption.

In a social media post, the food safety authority said that a regulatory sample of "pre-packed cumin powder" was drawn from the premises of the Goa-based Riverside Resorts & Holiday Homes.

"The food analyst's report found pesticide residues of Azoxystrobin and Thiamethoxam at levels exceeding the prescribed maximum limits. The analyst declared the sample 'unsafe' under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006," it noted.

It added that Everest Food Products was provided an opportunity to appeal against the report, following which the sample was referred to the referral food laboratory, which confirmed that the sample was unsafe.

"The entire implicated batch of 'pre-packed cumin powder' (Batch No E080668761) was directed to be recalled immediately from the market," the food safety regulator added.

The company was also directed to maintain complete records of the recalled product and submit the prescribed recall information and status reports within the stipulated timelines.

The FSSAI also directed the food business operator (FBO) to undertake corrective measures to prevent recurrence of the incident and submit a report upon completion of the recall.

Meanwhile, the regulator said it had suspended the licence of Creative Bakers and Confectioners due to severe hygiene deficiencies.

Kudankulam nuclear plant to add 1,000 MW capacity next year after Unit 3 starts: Rosatom

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The third unit of the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (NPP), with a capacity of 1,000 MW, is expected to commence operations by next year.

The Kudankulam project — India's largest nuclear power plant — is the flagship project of Russian-Indian technological and energy cooperation. The first two units have been operating successfully, at over design capacity of 1,020-1,030 MWt (megawatt thermal), supplying electricity to the entire southern region.

CONSTRUCTION PHASE

While the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) owns, operates and builds the plant, Rosatom — primarily through its engineering subsidiaries such Atomstroyexport — handles key technical areas, including the nuclear steam supply system and the core reactor technology.

Kirill Komarov, the First Deputy Director General for Corporate Development and International Business at Rosatom, told *businessline*: "Unit number three is very close to physical start-up. Maybe next year it can happen. Units 4, 5 and 6 are all in a very good construction phase, and at the end they will meet a significant share of the electricity needs of the State of Tamil Nadu — with a population of around 85 million — and neighbouring States with a combined population of over 100 million."



Kirill Komarov, First Deputy Director General for Corporate Development and International Business at Rosatom

Units 1 and 2 of the plant, with cumulative capacity of 2,000 MW are, operational. The project, located in Tirunelveli (Tamil Nadu), was conceived in 1988, and the construction began in 2002.

The first two units became operational in December 2014 and March 2017, respectively.

UNIT 3 PROGRESSION

As per the NPCIL, currently the manufacturing and progressive delivery of various equipment and components are in progress at unit 3.

Civil construction work of buildings like the reactor building, reactor auxiliary building and turbine building and hydro technical structures are in progress. The erection of the core catcher is completed.

"Since 2022, we have been supplying India with advanced nuclear fuel for Rosatom designed VVER-1000 reactors, enabling both operating units of the Kudankulam NPP to switch to an extended 18-month fuel cycle. The longer cycle will reduce the frequency of refuelling outages, enabling the units to generate more electricity and operate more cost-effectively," Komarov explained.

He emphasised that India's target of installing 100 gigawatt (GW) of nuclear powered capacity by 2047 is ambitious but achievable.

"Such an ambitious task is very difficult for only one company," he said, referring to the NPCIL, which currently operates and is building most of India's nuclear fleet.

LOCALISATION

Rosatom, he said, had already reached 50 per cent localisation at Kudankulam, and was ready to replicate the model with new Indian companies entering the nuclear sector.

Russia's State-owned nuclear energy corporation Rosatom, which accounts for about 20 per cent of Russia's power generation, ranks first globally in terms of the order portfolio size for constructing nuclear power plants (NPPs), with 46 units at various implementation stages across 10 countries, including China, India, Bangladesh, Türkiye, Egypt, Hungary, Iran and Kazakhstan.

NTT Data bets on India for global AI business

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India is emerging as a large contributor to NTT Data's global AI business as rising AI adoption, growing data generation and government-backed digital infrastructure drive demand, according to Avinash Joshi, Executive Managing Director – India, NTT Data.

"From a business potential standpoint, India generally contributes 3-4 per cent to the global business. In the case of AI, it may contribute more for two reasons — India is among the top four countries where AI adoption is increasing, and because 20 per cent of the global data today gets created here due to a large population and affordable data. I expect India's contribution to AI services, for both domestic and global requirements, to be higher than what it has been for the rest of IT services," he shared.

As a group, NTT is roughly a $93 billion telco-plus-IT-services company. The company's IT services business is now about $30 billion of that $93 billion.

"Currently, because of cybersecurity requirements, there is a lot of investment in the infrastructure space — compute, storage, network. People are investing in infrastructure for outcomes which won't come from the infrastructure itself, but from services," Joshi said.



Avinash Joshi, Executive Managing Director – India, NTT DATA

Outside its data centre business, more than 50 per cent of NTT Data's India business comes from IT services, including infrastructure management and application management services.

The company sees this segment as a key growth area, particularly with the increasing adoption of AI.

NTT Data previously said its India business was approaching $1 billion in revenue.

INDIA'S ROLE

"India's importance for us is three-dimensional — one is domestic growth, with the country being among the top 10 markets within our NTT world. The second reason is the availability of talent, and the third reason is the amount of innovation that comes out of India. We have an internal programme for filing patents, copyrights, and so on, and more than 50 per cent of the contribution comes from India."

The company has also decided to establish the headquarters of its security business in India and create an AI delivery hub in the country to serve its global operations.

NTT Data has already invested over $3 billion in India since 2011, and in 2025, it announced plans to invest another $1.5 billion annually for the next three years across data centre campuses, strategic acquisitions, submarine cables, renewable energy plants and an innovation centre in Bengaluru to research emerging technologies and applications.

The majority of the $1.5 billion investment, Joshi explained, will go into data centres — a capital-intensive business — and into creating capabilities.

The company is also investing in its 45,000-strong workforce through hiring, skilling and training, while expanding delivery centres in Mangaluru and Coimbatore, with the latter focused on AI. It also launched an innovation centre in Bengaluru focused on digital twins, AI and quantum operations. India is increasingly serving global operations, with NTT Data creating a chief growth office hub in the country and hiring around 100 people for global sales support.

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AI-driven recruitment goes mainstream, expands into non-tech professional roles

Rohan Das
Chennai

AI-powered recruitment, while previously associated mostly with software development and other technology jobs, is now expanding its reach to other non-tech professions.

Speaking to *businessline*, industry players said that while IT companies were early adopters of such tools and services, recruitment activity in sectors like manufacturing, retail, e-commerce and financial services is now being influenced by AI, especially for high-volume repetitive roles.

Jayanth Neelakanta, Founder and CEO, Equip, an AI-powered skill assessment and recruitment platform with over 1,000 customers, suggested that only about 35 per cent of the roles being recruited through the platform are now technology roles, with the rest being non-technical.

EXPANSION SCOPE

He said that this expansion of scope is primarily driven by AI's ability to dynamically create tests and assessment criteria for a wide variety of roles. "When we launched, we would focus on popular roles like a Python developer because we had to create questions and tests. But now it is more dynamic. On the fly, questions are being created based on the job description and a candidate's responses," he said.



AI technology is being used for recruitment in frontline and blue-collar work

Neelakanta cited an example of an e-commerce company that uses AI interviews to determine which store employees should be promoted to manager. The technology is also being used for recruitment in frontline and blue-collar work.

Satish Jeyaraman, Co-Founder & Chief Growth Officer, Berribot, an AI recruitment solutions provider, said over the past six months, it had collaborated with firms in sectors like retail manufacturing, pharma and healthcare for onboarding technicians, customer service executives and even cab/limousine drivers. The company serves over 30 clients in India, the US and Europe.

Jeyaraman said a key advantage of AI, especially for voluminous roles, is that panels no longer have to coordinate their availability with every candidate. "More than 60–70 per cent of candidates actually take interviews between 10 pm and 3 am, when they have better bandwidth and fewer disturbances. The AI interviewer is available 24x7, so candidates can simply click a link and take the interview when ready."

Meanwhile, job marketplaces, too, have begun infusing AI in their offerings.

Kartik Narayan, CEO, Apna, said 3,000-4,000 customers use its AI screening tools in a typical month. "One would assume the adoption of something like this is only among enterprises but we are seeing strong traction even within SMBs," he said.

TATA
TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173994) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following package.

1) **Outline Agreement Services for electrical work at various locations of Lonavala Headworks. (Tender ref no.CC27VB104).**
2) **Design, supply, installation and commissioning of MVWS system for the cable vaults at Khopoli, Bhira and Bhivpuri. (Tender ref no.CC27VB105).**

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before **1500 hrs. of 18th Oct 2026.** For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website **https://www.tatapower.com**. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website **(Tata Power > Business Associates > Tender Documents)** only.

ISGEC
ISGEC HEAVY ENGINEERING LIMITED
CIN: L23423HR1933PLC000097
Registered Office: Radaur Road, Yamunanagar – 135001, Haryana
Telephone: +91-1732-661061 / 661158
Email: roynr@isgec.com, **Website:** www.isgec.com

NOTICE

SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGEMENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES

This is to inform all concerned shareholders that pursuant to the SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, a special window for the re-lodgement of transfer deeds relating to physical shares has been opened for a period of one year from **February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027**. This Special Window is specifically available for physical shares sold or purchased by the shareholders prior to **April 01, 2019**, including cases where:

- Transfer requests were earlier submitted and rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiencies in documents or processes; or
- Such transfer requests are being lodged afresh, subject to fulfilment of prescribed conditions.

Please note that the shares so transferred under this Special Window shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one (1) year from the date of registration of transfer. Such shares shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period. Concerned shareholders are advised to take the advantage of this opportunity and re-lodge their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("RTA"), **Alankit Assignments Limited**, Alankit House, 4E/2, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi-110055, Tel: 011- 42541234, 23541234; Email: rta@alankit.com or ramap@alankit.com.

For **Isgec Heavy Engineering Limited**
Sd/-
Kalyan Ghosh
Compliance Officer
Membership No. A10790

Place : Noida
Date : 05.10.2026

TATA mutual fund

NOTICE

Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal under the Monthly Payout / Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option* of the following scheme. The record date for the same is 07 October, 2026.

Schemes - Plan / Option Name	Gross income distribution cum capital withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (₹)	NAV (₹) as on 30 Sep, 26
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Direct Plan*	0.77	10.00	93.4266
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Regular Plan*	0.77	10.00	76.8768

***(Monthly Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is not assured & is subject to the availability of distributable surplus).**

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).

Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realized gains.

** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax deducted at source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.

All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal.

Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal upto the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.

Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout /Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.

Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.

Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

NSE is betting big on technology, financialisation and market depth

GROWTH DRIVERS. Chairman Injeti and CEO Chauhan expect the exchange's future growth to be driven by a broader ecosystem

bl.interview

Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

With retail participation surging and demat accounts scaling new highs, India's capital markets are entering a new phase of growth. NSE Chairman Srinivas Injeti and MD & CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan said the focus is now shifting from merely expanding the investor base to deepening the financialisation of household savings. They expect the NSE's future growth to be driven by a broader ecosystem spanning equities, bonds, data, technology and global connectivity, while positioning India as an emerging global financial hub powered by innovation and market depth.

Edited excerpts:



> Our responsibility is to support this transition through investor education, transparent information and resilient market infrastructure
>
> **SRINIVAS INJETI,** Chairman, NSE



> The larger objective is to deepen financialisation by encouraging broader participation in equities, bonds, mutual funds and ETFs
>
> **ASHISHKUMAR CHAUHAN,** MD & CEO, NSE

India has seen a sharp rise in demat accounts and retail participation. What are the next big milestones for Indian capital markets?

Ashishkumar Chauhan: The next phase is not merely about adding more demat accounts. The larger objective is to deepen financialisation by encouraging broader participation in equities, bonds, mutual funds and ETFs. We also need greater market penetration beyond large cities and increased participation by SMEs in raising growth capital through capital markets.

Exchanges have a major role to play in making markets more accessible, transparent and resilient. Ultimately, the goal is to help India move from being a nation of savers to a nation of investors, while strengthening financial literacy and investor protection.

What are the biggest opportunities and risks for the NSE over the next decade?

Chauhan: The three biggest opportunities are the growth of India's economy and capital markets, increasing financialisation of household savings, and advances in technology and globalisation, including opportunities through GIFT IFSC. On the risk side, investor trust and market integrity remain paramount. Technology and cyber risks require constant vigilance as markets become increasingly digital. Another key challenge is adapting to regulatory and market developments without compromising investor protection.

Long-term value creation must come from strengthening the broader market ecosystem rather than relying on any single source of transaction revenue.

How do you view the NSE's dependence on derivatives revenue?

Srinivas Injeti: It is important to look beyond the perception that the NSE is purely options-driven.

Weekly options account for around 46 per cent of the NSE's revenue, while the balance comes from equities, futures, monthly options, indices, market data, terminals and other businesses.

Our effort is to broaden the revenue base further through products such as electricity futures, bond-index futures, electronic gold receipts and expanded market data and technology offerings. Derivatives will remain an important part of price discovery and risk management, but future growth should increasingly come from multiple asset classes and technology-led businesses.

The regulators have tightened norms around retail participation in derivatives. How has this changed market behaviour?

Chauhan: Such measures should primarily be viewed through the lens of investor protection and market quality. The objective is to ensure participation is informed, sustainable and backed by proper risk awareness. The market is adapting to changes in weekly options and retail participation norms.

While weekly options remain important, monthly options and futures continue to play a significant role. We are also seeing investors become more sophisticated as technology improves access to information. Our responsibility is to support this transition through investor education, transparent information and resilient market infrastructure.

Which businesses could emerge as the NSE's next growth engines?

Chauhan: We do not view products, technology, data and connectivity as separate silos. They reinforce one another. Data and technology have significant long-term potential because they can scale across markets and geographies without depending solely on trading volumes.

New products, such as electronic gold receipts, can also create opportunities by improving transparency and market-based price discovery. Growing demand for real-time data, analytics and portfolio-management tools is expected to further strengthen this segment.

Over time, the NSE can evolve from being primarily a transaction marketplace into a broader financial market technology and information platform.

Has the transition from SGX Nifty to GIFT Nifty delivered the intended results?

Injeti: The shift was aimed at bringing India-related price discovery closer home through GIFT IFSC. The objective was not simply to relocate a trading benchmark, but to create an international venue within India where global investors could access India-related products through a regulated ecosystem. Global investors will continue to use multiple financial centres, but the key achievement is that India now has a credible international platform attracting global liquidity. The long-term ambition is for India to become not just a recipient of global capital, but increasingly a price setter and a financial market hub.

How does the NSE respond to criticism that competition among exchanges is limited?

Chauhan: Competition should be measured by whether investors receive better products, lower friction, stronger innovation and greater efficiency. The NSE's market share reflects the liquidity, scale and technology that market participants have chosen, but that also creates a responsibility to continually raise standards. Our benchmark is increasingly global. New asset classes, technology investments and innovation in data and connectivity can deepen market development. Ultimately, competition that benefits investors strengthens the entire financial system.

Should exchanges eventually be allowed to list on their own platforms?

Injeti: Any decision on self-listing must be guided by market integrity and regulatory architecture. Strong safeguards, including independent oversight, surveillance mechanisms and a clear separation between regulatory and commercial functions, would be essential.

Globally, self-listing is common, but India's framework currently prefers exchanges listing on another exchange. Any future change would be a policy decision for the SEBI, with investor trust and market integrity remaining the overriding considerations.

Ahead of mega listing, Jio IPO roadshows draw strong investor interest

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Overseas roadshows conducted by Reliance Industries' digital arm, Jio Platforms, across the US, the UK, Dubai, Hong Kong and Singapore ahead of its proposed public listing have received an overwhelmingly positive response from investors.

The strong feedback has reinforced the company's confidence in proceeding with the IPO, despite the ongoing market volatility. The company may also undertake additional roadshows across India.

Jio is expected to be listed by the end of October at an enterprise valuation of $143-146 billion (over ₹12 lakh crore), according to media reports.

While *businessline* sources did not independently confirm the valuation, they indicated that the eventual pricing could be even higher than the current estimates.

Notably, Jio did not disclose any offer-for-sale (OFS) component in its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP), suggesting that the existing investors are not looking to dilute their holdings at the time of listing.

The company's marquee investors include Google, Meta and Silver Lake.

LARGEST IPO?

Jio's listing is expected to be the largest IPO in Indian history, surpassing Hyundai Motor India's ₹27,870-crore public issue in 2024.

In terms of market impact, analysts have previously indicated that even at a listing market capitalisation of ₹13-14 lakh crore, Jio would rank among the five most valuable listed companies in India.

Beyond attracting significant investor interest, the listing is expected to support the company's growth trajectory, which is already expanding around 20 per cent annually.

At this pace, Jio's market capitalisation could potentially reach ₹20 lakh crore within the next two to three years, bringing it on par with the current market value of its parent, Reliance Industries.

Ola Electric CMD pledges 4.32% to participate in rights issue

Press Trust of India
Bengaluru

Ola Electric Chairman and Managing Director Bhavish Aggarwal has pledged a 4.32 per cent stake in the company to participate in its rights issue, which was approved by the company's Board on September 28.

In a statement to the stock exchanges on Sunday, the company said, "Ola Electric promoter Bhavish Aggarwal has pledged a 4.32 per cent stake in the company to participate in the rights issue approved by the Board, as disclosed in the draft letter of offer filed on September 28."

More cash-out than capital raise: OFS gains ground in the IPO market

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

STRONG PIPELINE

- The IPO market raised a record ₹94,205 crore through 78 mainboard issues in the first half of FY27
- Of this, ₹55,695 crore, or 59%, came through OFS
- Fresh issues accounted for ₹38,510 crore, or 41%

The initial public offering (IPO) market raised a record ₹94,205 crore through 78 mainboard issues in the first half of FY27, but a larger share of the money went to existing shareholders selling their stakes rather than into companies as fresh capital.

Of the total amount raised between April and September, ₹55,695 crore, or about 59 per cent, came through offers for sale (OFS), while fresh issues accounted for ₹38,510 crore, or 41 per cent, according to Prime Database data.

In H1 FY26, fresh issues accounted for about 52 per cent of the ₹69,533 crore raised.

The shift was driven significantly by the ₹22,563-crore IPO of the National Stock Exchange, which was entirely OFS and accounted for nearly 24 per cent of the total H1 IPO fundraising. The issue allowed existing shareholders to sell their stakes, with no proceeds going to the NSE.

Excluding the NSE, the H1 FY27 IPO market raised about ₹71,642 crore, only around 3 per cent higher than the ₹69,533 crore raised in H1 FY26. OFS proceeds, excluding of the NSE, stood about ₹33,132 crore, marginally below the ₹33,356 crore recorded in H1 FY26.

So, the increase in OFS-led fundraising was largely concentrated on the NSE issue, rather than a broad-based shift towards shareholder exits across the IPO market.

FRESH CAPITAL UP

Fresh capital, meanwhile, increased 6.4 per cent year-on-year to ₹38,510 crore from about ₹36,177 crore in H1 FY26. However, the increase was much slower than the 35 per cent growth in overall IPO fundraising.

A significant portion of the fresh capital was directed towards strengthening company balance sheets. About 42 per cent of fresh issue proceeds went towards repayment of debt, according to Prime Database.

The primary market also saw a sharp increase of 20 per cent in the number of companies accessing the mainboard, with 78 issues in H1 FY27 compared to 65 in the year-ago period. However, this did not lead to a similar increase in the size of the typical issue. Activity was also heavily concentrated in the latter part of the half, with companies raising only ₹3,794 crore in April-June, before fundraising accelerated to ₹28,648 crore in July, ₹22,453 crore in August and ₹39,340 crore in September.

September alone accounted for more than 40 per cent of H1 fundraising, with 34 companies raising ₹39,340 crore.

The strong pipeline suggests IPO activity could remain elevated in the second half, with nearly 250 companies seeking to raise about ₹4.65 lakh crore, according to Prime Database.

SEBI gets 20,000 comments on CAS review

Our Bureau
Mumbai

FEEDBACK

Market participants mostly seek continuation of the 30-minute CTS VWAP before any shift to a blended settlement methodology

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has received 20,000 comments on its consultation paper on the closing auction session (CAS), market timings and derivatives settlement methodology by the final day for submissions, as the regulator prepares to review feedback before finalising the framework.

The response has increased significantly since the over 3,500 comments cited earlier by SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey a week ago. A large part of the feedback from traders and other market participants favoured retaining the existing last 30-minute continuous trading session (CTS) volume-weighted average price (VWAP) as the interim methodology for settling index and single-stock derivatives on expiry days, rather than immediately moving to a blended VWAP that includes the CAS.

TWO OPTIONS

The market regulator had proposed two options: The settlement price would be based on a blended VWAP of trades during the final 30 minutes of CTS and the 10-minute CAS or else go back to the existing CTS-only VWAP for at least a year before a possible transition to the blended methodology.

The Futures Industry Association (FIA), in its response submitted on October 3, strongly backed the second option. It said the blended methodology would be difficult for participants to track because the relative weights of CTS and CAS would only be known after the auction, while the CTS portion would have to be executed beforehand.

This, the FIA said, could create settlement-price mismatch for funds hedging portfolios through index futures, arbitrageurs whose derivatives positions are hedged against underlying stocks, and investors using derivatives to obtain market exposure. It recommended that any eventual move to a blended VWAP be linked to a clearly defined liquidity trigger showing that CAS had sufficient liquidity to form part of the derivatives settlement.

The FIA also supported SEBI's proposed Option A on market timings, under which continuous trading in CAS stocks would run until 3.30 pm, followed by the auction, with derivatives trading until 3.45 pm. It said the longer continuous session would support price discovery and bring the derivatives closer to the completion of the cash market closing process.

TIGHTER CURBS

However, the FIA opposed SEBI's proposal to stop disseminating the indicative index value during CAS as it could reduce transparency and make it harder for participants and exchanges to assess the relationship between the index, its constituents and derivatives during the auction.

The consultation also proposed tighter restrictions on cancellation of orders placed beyond 1 per cent of the reference price, changes to the treatment of unexecuted Iceberg orders and a shorter transition between continuous trading and CAS.



the hindu businessline.
MONDAY - OCTOBER 5, 2026

Bite the bullet

A strong case for MPC to change course

The current Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), since it was re-constituted in October 2024, has consistently displayed a tilt towards growth over inflation. In January to December 2025, aided by sub-4 per cent inflation prints, it trimmed the repo rate by 125 basis points to 5.25 per cent to lift the economy out of a slowdown.

Between February and July 2026, as the Iran conflict flared up and reignited both inflation and growth concerns, it held off rate hikes, keeping its powder dry to respond to incoming data. In July, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced its FCNR(B) scheme to tempt inbound flows and stem the bout of rupee depreciation brought on by war. These measures succeeded in bringing in $127 billion in dollar flows and shored up the rupee. However, with India's growth holding strong and the Iran conflict showing no sign of early resolution, the upcoming meeting next week seems to be a good time for the MPC to consider a 25-basis point repo hike.

A rate hike now seems prudent on four counts. One, with ceasefire attempts repeatedly breaking down, Brent crude prices, which had plummeted below $80 in July, are back to the $100/barrel mark now. Though India has diversified its supply lines beyond the Strait of Hormuz, fresh disruptions to the East-West pipeline in Saudi Arabia and US legislation slapping punitive tariffs on countries buying oil from Russia, are pushing up energy and fertilizer costs.

Data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell show the price of India's crude oil basket at $116/barrel in September from just $82 in July. Two, CPI (consumer price index) inflation, which remained below 4 per cent until April, shot up to 4.82 per cent in August on the back of rising fuel prices. With oil price risks re-emerging, it appears unlikely that inflation will be contained within the bounds of the RBI's 4.7 per cent forecast this quarter. Three, the impact of El Nino on food prices has so far been muted, despite the deficient South-West monsoon. But with low soil moisture and the El Nino still going strong, risks to the rabi crop and thus, food inflation, are far from over.

The most important factor that argues for a policy rate hike at this juncture is the fresh onslaught on the rupee with a renewed barrage of FPI selling in Indian stocks in recent weeks. With the return of global inflation fears, bond yields in the developed world have risen sharply. The US 10-year gilt trades at a 25-year high, Japan at a 30-year high and so on. Higher bond yields in these markets usually lead to FPIs switching on their risk-off mode in emerging markets.

What's more, Japan and European Central Bank are already in a rate hiking cycle, while the US Federal Reserve effected its first hike this month. With rate differentials between India and these markets shrinking, the MPC cannot risk falling behind the curve in defending the rupee. For monetary policy actions to have an impact, they need to pre-empt markets rather than follow them.

OTHER VOICES.

South China Morning Post

No silver bullet for Hong Kong's falling birth rate

Despite a government cash incentive for young couples to have children, Hong Kong's birth rate continues to fall. It is driving the ageing of a society in which one in four people is projected to be 65 or over by 2028. Unless the trend is arrested, one in three residents is projected to be 65 or over by the 2040s. One projection puts the number of elderly residents at 2.74 million by 2046. Granted, it is not all bad news. One reason for the population ageing is increased longevity. But the fact remains that we can expect proportionately fewer younger people to support more elderly residents, while proportionately more people may need elderly care. As a result, three years ago, the government launched its HK$20,000 baby-bonus scheme to lift the birth rate, setting aside HK$2.28 billion ($291 million) to fund it over three years. (HONG KONG, OCTOBER 4)

讀賣新聞 THE YOMIURI SHIMBUN

Activities of actual benefit to society are essential

Now is not the time to engage in political activities with strong ideological overtones. Since public funds are being used, hopefully the Science Council of Japan will contribute to society from the perspective of genuine academic research. The SCJ has been reorganized from a "special national organization" to a special corporation. This marks the first organizational reform since its establishment in 1949. Similar academic organizations in Europe and the United States are not government agencies. Also, from the position of independence, this transition to a special corporation is appropriate. The corporation needs to transform itself so that it delivers tangible results in order to gain broad public support. (TOKYO, OCTOBER 3)

Impossibility of a Paretian EC

NAME OF THE GAME. SIR should not be abandoned. There is a Constitutional requirement that it be conducted

LINE & LENGTH.



TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN



TOUGH JOB. There should be a way of dealing with the issue of multiple spellings of similar names THE HINDU

For over a year now, there has been huge opposition to the Special Intensive Review (SIR) of voters list. The revelations in the *Indian Express* have made things much worse. Everyone is saying that democracy is under threat. No one says, though, that the SIR should be cancelled. They only want a new election commission (EC) or a new chief election commissioner.

To add spice to the arguments, the opponents are saying that the names of around 13 crore voters have been deleted. But this is not as alarming as it sounds because between 27,000 and 28,000 people die in India everyday. That comes to around a crore people dead every year. Taken over a decade, that's 10 crore people whose names will be struck off.

Or should be and haven't. And that's another EC mystery because the number of dead people deleted is much smaller at about 20 per cent only. Why? Meanwhile, the norm in the large western democracies of voters being dropped from electoral lists is between 8 and 12 per cent. Most of this is because people die or move.

In India, therefore, even with a deletion rate of 10 per cent, around 10 crore people will get dropped anyway. The only question is whether they are alive or dead. In either case it is probably because of incompetence rather than *mala fide*. So, a large part of it is subject to correction. That too has been happening, but altogether too slowly and cumbersomely.

THE SHARMA CRITIQUE

So, what else is the fuss about? It's about the people who are alive and should not have been left out. Why this has happened has been explained in a devastating critique of the Election Commission by RS Sharma, the former head of TRAI and the National Health Authority. He says that in India it's impossible to identify all voters. The diversity of the spellings of names alone, not to mention all other diversities, is such that there cannot be a one-to-one mapping of all Indian voters with their identity, even when the person typing the name gets all the elements right. Mistakes are often made.

Years ago I received a letter from the Planning Commission with my name written as Ghavan Srinivas Ra. The same thing happened with my father's name, too, and my sister's. And a Suri can also be Surie and a Bahel, Behl or a Brijeshwar, Birjesvar or Vrijeshwar.

Sharma concludes his long paper saying that in an "experiment in 2006-08, when Wipro's match across the real voter, PDS and BPL databases — reported in some two dozen volumes — was found futile because Indian names and addresses could not be reconciled".

> **I received a letter from Planning Commission** with my name written as Ghavan Srinivas Ra. The same thing happened with my father's name, too, and my sister's

He goes on to say that "uniqueness demanded of the UIDAI, thereafter, which found even fingerprints insufficient at a billion scale, and had to add iris scans, while consigning demographic matching to a hand-checked fallback for a fraction of one per cent".

He writes next that there is "the Election Commission's own admission to the Supreme Court, in November 2025, that its demographic de-duplication software was defective". He finally concludes that "the Supreme Court has upheld the Commission's power to conduct this exercise; it has not endorsed...the reliability of the method by which the exercise decides whom to strike off".

PARETO CRITERION AND SIR

So, should the whole SIR exercise be abandoned? No, because there is a Constitutional requirement that it be conducted. So, the only issue is of doing it in a way that meets Sharma's very valid objections. Here, if readers will pardon me, a bit of economics will be useful. We need to recall what the 19th century Italian economist said about change and its impact on social welfare. His name was Vilfredo Pareto, and he left behind a criterion for evaluating change in social welfare. It's called the Pareto Criterion. It says a change improves social welfare if at least one person is better off and no one is worse off. This condition proved impossible to satisfy, so two 20th century economists, Nicholas Kaldor and John Hicks, tweaked it. They said if total gains from a change exceed total losses, that's good.

But another economist spotted a logical flaw in this. His name was Tibor Scitovsky. He came up with a third criterion, namely that potential losers from a change shouldn't be able to bribe the potential winners to remain in the previous situation. This would be very rare, but theoretically it could happen.

Now, try these criteria on SIR to see which one works best. Scitovsky notwithstanding, I would opt for the second one, the Kaldor-Hicks criterion, where total gains from a change exceed total losses. This would push the fairness or procedural question to the second place.

A test for forward guidance in monetary policy

Given the complex set of dynamic considerations, the MPC's communication will be keenly watched

A Vasudevan

The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meetings in the first week of every second month pose difficulties because information sets are rarely up-to-date. When the MPC meets on October 5, it must also reckon with the noise emerging from the geopolitical and geoeconomic ecosystem. Questions arising from these two factors test the ability of the committee to provide forward guidance to markets. Here are some key considerations that need to be weighed in for providing future guidance of the monetary policy.



MPC'S MESSAGE. Up-to-date communication is important

FOREX RESERVES

The first is forex reserves, which as of September 18, stood at $766 billion. This covers over nine months of average imports, but supply chain disruptions and stretched export capacities could raise the adequacy of reserves. What should be done to raise the reserves to 12 months of imports?

The exchange rate at ₹95.79 to the US dollar as of September 18 tells us that the schemes for attracting forex inflows, such as through FCNR(B) deposits, did not help reduce the likely rupee depreciation. Is there a guarantee that it will promote exports and impede imports? How much depreciation could be tolerated over the year? The MPC must have a view on these questions.

The CAD to GDP ratio is about 0.5 per cent. If import prices of critical inputs such as oil, minerals and chips go up beyond the perceived tolerable levels, this ratio could be 1-2 per cent. On liquidity, there is a large surplus in the system.

To suck excess liquidity, measures, including incremental CRR, could be deployed. Perhaps, the credit norms will be relaxed. This will raise supervisory costs and cause disruptions in economic units' portfolios, with possibly large equity investments driving up share prices with implications for financial stability. Besides, large credit flows leading to a rise in M3 could propel inflation upticks.

RISING INTEREST RATES

International interest rates are on an uptick. The US, UK and Japan are good examples of this. Will this lead to a repo rate hike? The gap between the rate abroad and Indian rate will shrink and may affect forex inflows. Should India hike repo rate by 25 basis points or by 30-50 basis points? Will the hike transmit favourable effects on the goals of policy? And how will the yield curve be then? Should long rates also go up, say to 7.50 per cent, from the present 7.08 per cent without disrupting the levels of economic activity?

The fiscal deficit to GDP ratio is probably at over 4.5 per cent today. This could go up further if import prices increase and accelerate inflation, given the large expenditure needs due to an expected slowdown in agricultural production, high defence needs, large R&D expenditures in the light of technological advances and costs arising from August and September measures to ensure large forex inflows.

Will this not require coordination with the government, which is faced with resource constraints? How will the MPC determine the acceptable fiscal constraint?

There is also the issue of inventory build-up. Information on strategic reserves of all minerals and critical inputs is not readily available but can be estimated. This is the time for inventory limits to be stretched to at least six months of production requirements from the conventional three to four months, given the emerging geopolitical and geo-economic situations.

COMMUNICATION IS KEY

How the communication about the MPC meeting will be worked out is a question for which not much thought has been given as yet, even though some stray articles/speeches on the subject have appeared in the RBI bulletins in the past. In fact, one needs to also take into account that forward guidance of policy would be tested in future meetings as well as domestic and international developments unfold. Market estimates of official rates and regulatory issues will be more of theoretical interest. What counts most now is the way monetary policy communications through the RBI Governor's statement are conveyed immediately after each meeting.

The writer is a former Executive Director of RBI and an independent economic analyst. Views are personal. Through The Billion Press

BELOW THE LINE



Ground reality

After surviving a mid-air cockpit attack and saving 174 passengers on a flydubai flight to Tel Aviv, Captain Smit Machchhar is being celebrated worldwide. But as Indian officials line up to praise him and discuss military honours, India's pilot community sees a sharp irony.

Machchhar is an aviation refugee who left India for better conditions; his ex-employees in SpiceJet have faced severe salary delays, and pilots consistently battle the DGCA over gruelling work schedules. As a viral X post put it: "Smit left India for a better life... yet now, everyone is fighting to claim his glory."

On record

The market has long suspected a leadership disconnect at the top, but a public mic-snatch just confirmed it. During a post-listing media briefing, this Chairman took the microphone directly from the Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, snapping, "you talk too long", before fielding questions himself.

Though masked as light-hearted banter, the exchange highlighted a long-standing clash of styles.

Industry circles reveal that the company's public messaging has been heavily managed to disguise this executive friction since well before the listing.

Cropped out

Tech glitches brought unexpected humour to a recent rabi crop conference. When Fertiliser Secretary Rajat Kumar Mishra's microphones died on stage, Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan dryly noted: "Fertiliser has an issue, it seems." Mishra was forced to present from the audience floor. Moments later, the next speaker, Additional Secretary Pramod Kumar Mehrda, lost his projector screen. Told by Chouhan to ditch the slides and keep it brief, Mehrda spoke off-the-cuff, only for the screen to turn back on right as he finished.

Scoop by fire

Move over walking interviews, stairwell evacuations are the new trend. When a fire drill suddenly interrupted a chat with a financial services CXO, the reporter didn't stop recording. Instead, the executive and the journalist kept the conversation flowing while navigating five flights of stairs alongside 3,000 employees who were evacuating. Fire drill or not, the work simply had to go on.

Not NICE

Three decades after its 1995 inception, the unfinished Bengaluru-Mysuru NICE Road has triggered a fierce political war. Over 14,000 acres of prime land were forcibly seized from local farmers for pennies, while the private developer pocketed ₹4,000-plus crore in toll revenue. Now, CM DK Shivakumar and Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy are locked in a bitter slinging match over profiteering. This feud is a raw proxy battle to control the dominant Vokkaliga community, which bore the brunt of the land acquisitions.

AI and ingenuity

Can code copy culture? Not a chance. Industry titan Prasoon Joshi stepped into the AI boxing ring to defend local voices against digital homogenisation. Drawing lines from *Thanda Matlab Coca-Cola* to Google's Kumaoni push, the Prasar Bharati Chairman argues that tech's existential limit is human authenticity. AI is a trained copycat trapped inside existing datasets. It cannot touch the unexpressed human trauma, joy and localised memory that is yet to be digitised. In a world of synthesised content, your unshared human experience is your greatest competitive weapon.

Our Bureaus

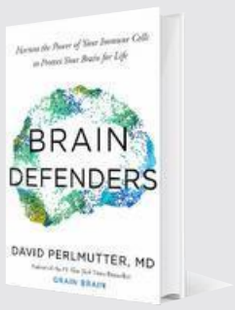
Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai-600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., and Printed by Ra Babu Vijay at THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Plot B-6 & B-7, CMDA Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu Dist., Pin: 603209. Editor: Raghuvir Srinivasan (Editor responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 7528

A window into brain care

The book brings brain health into sharp focus

BOOK REVIEW.

Bina Berry



Title: Brain Defenders: How to Protect Your Brain for Life
Author: Dr David Perlmutter
Publisher: Yellow Kite/Hachette

A morning walk in fresh air; a carefully chosen meal; a health check-up faithfully scheduled; a resolution to get enough sleep — we give considerable thought to keeping ourselves well. Yet, how often does that attention travel above the neck? Dr David Perlmutter's *Brain Defenders* brings the brain into this familiar conversation with an enthusiasm that is difficult to resist. Here is a book that makes one curious about an organ we depend upon for everything and yet take for granted.

Microglia, resident immune cells of the central nervous system, are the stars of Perlmutter's book. He describes their protective functions and how —when these are disturbed — they can contribute to the very damage they should help prevent. The question running through the book is an absorbing one: how might we help these defenders remain on our side?

What appeals about the book particularly is the connection the author draws between the health of the body and that of the brain. We readily discuss immunity, inflammation and the benefits of eating well, but tend to imagine that most of this activity happens somewhere below the neck. Perlmutter encourages us to widen our view. Metabolism and brain health belong in the same conversation; caring for one means paying attention to the other.

SCIENCE FOR ALL

This is a book with much to take in — diet and alcohol; prescribed medicines and environmental toxins; stress, sleep, genetics and ageing. Happily, the reader does not need a medical degree to follow along. Perlmutter explains unfamiliar science in an approachable language, giving the ordinary reader a way into a subject that might otherwise feel forbiddingly technical. The pleasure lies in making connections between what happens quietly within us and the choices that fill an ordinary day.

One thought stayed with me: the health difficulties we associate with later in life may have histories reaching much further back. This gives the book's emphasis on prevention an immediacy that a discussion confined to old age would lack. There is something compelling about attending to the roots of illness before its symptoms begin to command our lives. It also makes this a book for younger readers, who may scarcely have given their future brain health a thought. The chapters on 'Breakthrough Therapies' and 'Promising Pharmaceuticals' bring a particular excitement.

They open a window to the discoveries and interventions Perlmutter believes could improve the future of brain care. His questioning of established treatment approaches also raises an important concern: how should patients weigh the benefits of a medicine against its risks?

These chapters invite curiosity, alongside careful attention to the distinction between promising research and established treatment. The possibility is exciting, but readers need to know how far the evidence has travelled.

That is where questions on the book's invitation to take charge of our health come up. Having a part to play in our health is encouraging; feeling wholly responsible for its outcome is a different matter. Lifestyle changes may help reduce risk, but they cannot guarantee freedom from disease.

TIME TO THINK

If brain health has been a distant concern, *Brain Defenders* brings it closer. If it has already occupied your thoughts, the book offers plenty to consider. Its accessibility is its great strength: a common reader can enter this unfamiliar world and emerge with both interest and a sense of involvement.

The reviewer is a public affairs specialist and a board member and counsellor with the Alzheimer's and Related Disorder Society of India, a non-profit in the space of dementia

'Maggi was the vortex of the storm'

Former Nestlé India chief Suresh Narayanan talks about surviving an existential crisis in his book *Courage Under Fire*

bl.interview

Vinay Kamath


Suresh Narayanan, former Chairman & MD, Nestle India

In this conversation on his book, *Courage Under Fire*, Suresh Narayanan, former Chairman & Managing Director, Nestle India, talks about his life influences and how he managed various crises during his time with the company. He says a people-centred style of leadership is what is important for a company's performance. *Edited excerpts:*

Nestle was like a black box to the media earlier as the company had very few interactions with the press. And then you came in when the Maggi crisis happened and opened up to all stakeholders, communicating often. Is that one of your tenets of leadership?

The history of Nestle in India has been of a respectable, high-performing company, but a company that was reticent, one that never shared much with the media. As times change, I think policies of the company also underwent a change. And I think the crisis, in some sense, exacerbated the need for making a shift, which happened under my watch.

To really share what can be shared, to be open, transparent and thereby build both trust and share information as is relevant to the context. I think it's also in my own style of management that I like to communicate as much and as deeply as I can to stakeholders, to employees and to other entities in the system. It was an essential element during the crisis to be able to communicate, especially for a company that had been accused of not communicating enough.

Would you say the Maggi crisis was the most challenging in your career because it was virtually an existential issue?

Yes, in terms of size, scale, dimension and impact, I would say the Maggi crisis was the biggest that I have faced. Crises like the Arab Spring or Covid or indeed the Singapore meltdown that happened due to Lehman Brothers were not of an existential nature. It was a more societal issue that had been brought to bear.

Maggi was the vortex of the storm. And a suitable response had to be given to that. And yes, if it had gone the wrong way, it might have meant serious damage to the company and its future.

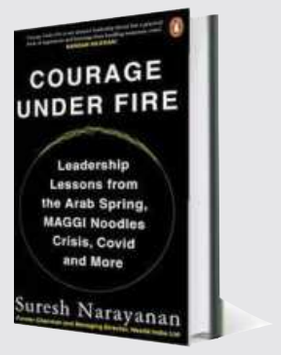
You've talked about it in various forums, but can you briefly recapitulate how you handled the Maggi crisis, which was so essential to the core of the company?

The Maggi crisis was a regulatory misunderstanding of enormous proportions. The testing, the quality of testing and the veracity of the testing were all being called to question. And normally, in any environment, these are challenged with the company which has been accused.

Here, unfortunately, it went straight to the media. And then it blew up into a media storm. And also, lo and behold, we had to withdraw 39,000 tonnes of product from the shelf, from about five million outlets. So, that was 30 per cent of the business of the company at that point in time which was frozen. And the other parts of the business also, therefore, started to shake because the name Nestle was involved. The reputational damage was all across.

So, there were issues at four levels. The issue was, first of all, employees. Nestle is a tenure company; people spend 20 to 40 years in the company. Generally, the culture has been very respectful, dignified and very loyalty-based. So, there was a critical threat to the employment of my colleagues, which I had to assuage at that point in time.

The second one was the environment itself. It had become quite hostile. It was fortunately the pre-social media age of significance. So, we were able to address various stakeholders.



Title: *Courage Under Fire*
Author: Suresh Narayanan
Publisher: Penguin Business
Price: 434

And then, of course, the impact on stakeholders — the distributors, suppliers. Their supplies came to a grinding halt. How were they to run their businesses? So, there were multifarious issues that were involved. The first task of mine was to take up people-related issues. That's what I felt was most important.

And that was my strategy all along. First, put the people who are in the line of fire comfortable with what they are facing and support them as best as you can. This meant managing yourself as a leader and also managing the environment as well employees. And over a period of time, build on the trust and transparency of the company.

We had taken the matter to court, the Mumbai High Court, where we ultimately won. And that was a significant pivoting point for the company. Because it allowed us to retest the products again and relaunch them. And, in fact, in all the 3,500 tests that had been done till then, not one sample had failed. Once that happened, then the relaunch process came into place and Maggi came roaring back.

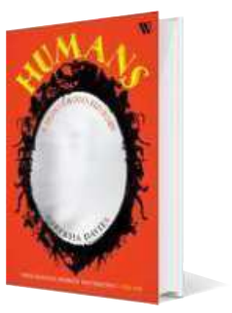
What would you say are the key takeaways from the book for young managers aspiring for leadership roles?

Leadership perspectives are important in one's leadership journey. A people-centred leadership based on values, culture and credibility with a focus on outcomes can lead to high performance. So, there is nothing, no sacrifices being made. And this is a lived journey.

None of the pages in my book have got any theories of leadership or theories of management around it. Because I felt that it has to be narrated in the raw form. In the form in which I've lived it with no varnishing. So, things like trust, respect, dignity, pride, credibility, compassion, empathy are important to us not just as human beings but as leaders. That's all I would like to offer the next generation as a leadership model that they may or may not like to adopt in this hyper-volatile age that they are going to work in.

The interviewer is a veteran journalist and author of *Titan: Inside India's Most Successful Consumer Brand*
Read full interview on www.thehindubusinessline.com

NEW READS.



Title: Humans: A Monstrous History
Author: Surekha Davis
Publisher: Westland Non-Fiction

The books reveals how people have defined the human in relation to everything from apes to zombies, and how they invented race, gender and nations along the way



Title: Version Infinity - Entrepreneurship, Pivoting and the Pursuit of Possibilities
Author: Akash Gupta
Publisher: Harper Collins

The book chronicles Gupta's extraordinary path as he breaks away from the conventional middle-class route to take bold risks, close ventures and start anew



Title: Framing The Future: India And Language In A Multipolar Age
Author: Peggy Mohan
Publisher: Penguin Allen Lane

How new technologies are making it possible to bridge linguistic divides without erasing the country's astonishing diversity

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

October 5, 2006

Oil companies make profit on petrol sales

With the softening of international crude prices, OMCs have started making marginal profit of Rs 1.50 per litre in retail sale of petrol and almost breaking even on diesel sales. However, the consumer may have to wait before any price revision is considered, as the Government wants to watch the trend, since the companies continue to bleed on sale of subsidised kerosene and cooking gas.

UPA, Left meet remains inconclusive

The four Left parties supporting the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) Government from outside remained dissatisfied after today's meeting of the UPA-Left Co-ordination Committee, with the Government not accepting their views on issues ranging from SEZs, farmer suicides and foreign investments to public distribution systems and pending Bills.

Tatas' passenger vehicle set for early 2007 launch

Tata Motors is gearing up for an early 2007 launch for its newest offering, a people transporter, developed around Renault's 'Trafik' model from the Pune facilities. The company has already developed two versions of the product codenamed Panel V, a high dome and a flat roof model.

Short take

Rooting out mischief in the skies — a pipe dream?

RK Raghavan

A series of recent disasters in the skies have shaken our confidence in civil aviation authorities, particularly private airlines' ability to guarantee passenger safety.

The latest mishap involving a flydubai aircraft operating from Dubai to Tel Aviv should send shivers down the spine of international travellers. Looks as if, apart from the reliability of the equipment and the skill of the cockpit crew, we need to worry about their political and religious persuasion.

We want on board only those who have proven rectitude and a determination to steer clear of their non-professional personal predilections. Preliminary reports indicate that an Omani national with terror leanings was the co-pilot to an Indian captain. The debate whether he was a lone wolf acting on his own, or was sponsored by a terrorist outfit, is not wholly relevant here.

The most damaging information is that he had earlier been sacked from another airline after being found to have strong religious leanings. Why was this vital fact ignored when Fly Dubai hired him?

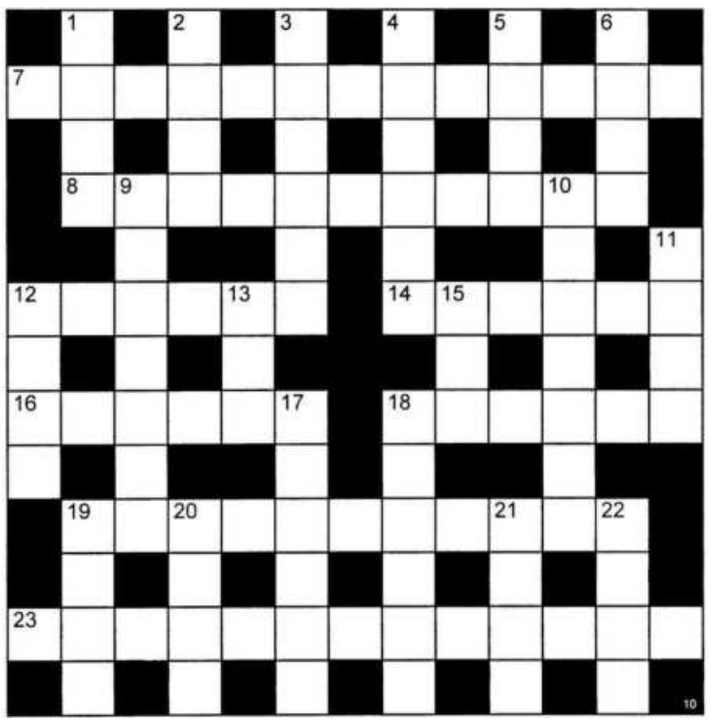
What kind of background checks are prospective crew members subjected to before coming on board? We frequently hear that the laid down protocol is solid and is observed to the core. This was possibly credible until a few years ago when air traffic was not too large for strict implementation of standards. With profits shrinking and basic expenditures mounting, it is often difficult to believe that everything necessary for passenger security and comfort is taken care of.

A specific question is how compatibility of the pilot and co-pilot is ensured. Is the posting to the cockpit at random, or is there a system that goes beyond mere availability? Do the two know in advance as to who will be together? This could be a ridiculous question. It is not mere temperamental compatibility that is involved here. Ethnic issues are also relevant. This may be an outrageous and unethical suggestion. Consider a Russian-Ukranian complement in the cockpit or an Israeli-Iranian team there. This may seem hypothetical but my fears are not. In the flydubai incident, imagine what would have happened if the seriously injured captain had not been able to unlatch the lock. How do we provide for a fisticuff in the cockpit?

This is a difficult question to answer. Just as we assign the seats close to an emergency exit to a handful of able-bodied passengers, can we permit limited access to the cockpit to one or two passengers? The International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO) has its task cut out.

The writer is a former CBI Director

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2749



EASY

ACROSS

7. A reliable quality (13)
8. It is to be pressed in an emergency (5,6)
12. Esteem, estimation (6)
14. Concerning teeth (6)
16. Maker of suits (6)
18. A point in time (6)
19. Selection of Stilton, Brie etc as presented (11)
23. In very plentiful supply (13)

DOWN

1. A bound (4)
2. Bracken (4)
3. Extracted, drawn out (6)
4. Ridiculous (6)
5. (Blood) coagulate (4)
6. College opposite Windsor (4)
9. Terrible pain (7)
10. Outgrow, outlive (7)
11. Even, level (4)
12. Parrot-fashion, mechanical repetition (4)
13. A marsupial, in short (3)
15. One's self, 'I' (3)
17. Rogue, knave (6)
18. _____ strip : one-sided surface twisted and joined (6)
19. An iron or a wood (4)
20. Uniform, smooth (4)
21. Tots up (4)
22. Unpleasantly moist (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

7. Quality one can rely on if one has the skill to follow it (13)
8. One will be frightened to press it (5,6)
12. Look at the respect one is held in (6)
14. It's concerning the teeth of lad, ten of which are crooked (6)
16. Turning to liar, he may suit one (6)
18. Measure of turning effect takes but a tick (6)
19. On which the directors are first offered Cheddar (11)
23. It's pasture, and nub of it is that it's in over-plentiful supply (13)

DOWN

1. Jump an extra day for one year in four (4)
2. Plant that produces iron with the Navy (4)
3. It is drawn out as one lost weight right from the beginning (6)
4. It is ridiculous, confusing us with the Bard (6)
5. An embolism forming on top of leg when in bed (4)
6. One might remark the turn-up of such a collar (4)
9. It is torture giving his gun a whirl (7)
10. The clothes last longer in a tour we have organised (7)
11. It is unexciting, such accommodation (4)
12. Was an author, as one heard in mechanical memory (4)
13. A jumper is an essential part of grooming, in short (3)
15. One's self is involved in the goings-on (3)
17. What a rogue the Lascar turns out to be! (6)
18. August F twisted through 180° in doing his strip (6)
19. It might be a wood cudgel (4)
20. It is as smooth as a septet without a leader (4)
21. Is going on to say how one puts it on (4)
22. In Sudan, Kitchener found it unpleasantly moist (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2748

ACROSS 1. Prop forward 7. Trample 9. Smut 11. Osier 12. Dynamo 14. Pyrotechnic 18. Normal 20. Cache 22. Clam 23. Willing 24. Choirmaster

DOWN 2. Reality 3. Open 4. Rumba 5. Stoop 6. Strop 8. Personal 10. Mythical 13. Pet 15. Incline 16. Snack 17. Wedge 19. Roach 21. Swim

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - OCTOBER 5 - 2026

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

Festive fervour and incentives to shop are flooding the ad space. Regulator FSSAI's recent actions have spurred brands to start conversations around food quality too

Discounted luck



Flipkart is going all out to promote its Big Billion Days with a spate of quirky campaigns. It even brings numerology into the equation, tying up with Sanjay B Jumaani for an activation. Conceptualised and created by McCann, the campaign gives the familiar question "What's in a name?" a festive shopping twist. Shoppers visit www.luckbynaam.com and enter their name. The website calculates a numerology score based on the spelling of the name and reveals the discount linked to that score.

Beyond the pack



Building on the conversations around adulteration, ZOFF Foods' 'Know The Brand' campaign gets its brand ambassador Shilpa Shetty to encourage consumers to look beyond price and packaging familiarity, and pay closer attention to the products they bring into their kitchens. The latest campaign asks consumers to look beyond what is visible on a pack and understand what goes into the journey of the spices they buy — from where they are sourced and how the raw materials are selected, to how they are cleaned, processed, tested, stored and packaged.

NUGGETS.

Commerce-first brand launch playbook



WPP Media India has just launched 'From Concept to Scale: The Commerce-First Launch Playbook for India', a framework showing that the future of new product launches is no longer just campaign-driven but also decisively commerce-first. It highlights a fundamental shift where commerce platforms have evolved from mere points of transaction into full-funnel innovation engines for demand discovery, validation and agile scale-up. Combining insights from leading platforms, brand case studies and industry specialists, the playbook explores the evolving dynamics that are reshaping how brands take products to market. It shows how commerce-first launch strategies allow brands to capture behavioural proof over stated intent, test propositions in real shopping environments and de-risk national rollouts.

Sandeep Goyal voted president of AAAI



The Advertising Agencies Association of India (AAAI), the apex body of ad agencies and media buying houses, unanimously elected Sandeep Goyal, Chairman and MD of Rediffusion, as its President for 2026-27. The AAAI celebrated its 80th anniversary earlier this year.

Goyal, who has authored 10 books, has been in the ad and media business since 1984, starting off in HTA (now VML), then doing stints at Trikaya Grey (now Grey Worldwide) and Mudra (now DDB). He became Rediffusion president in 1997 and Group CEO of Zee in 2001. He was India JV Partner and Chairman of Dentsu India and Middle East from 2003-11. He was Chairman of the advisory board of Snapchat India, besides serving three years in the Punjab government as Principal Secretary. In 2021, he bought Rediffusion and Everest.

◉ VIEWERSHIP CODE

The great chase for audience attention

SPLINTERED SCREEN. From *Drishyam 3* to microdramas, India's ₹59,000-cr entertainment industry is grappling with an audience puzzle

Amit Vijay Mohile



SHOW AND TELL. Stars and star makers deliberating on the economics of showbiz at Ficci FRAMES 2026

Bollywood veteran Ajay Devgn has spent more than three decades making films for the Hindi mass market. At Ficci FRAMES, the convention on the business of media and entertainment held in Mumbai, where the *Singham* star was promoting *Drishyam 3*, he acknowledged a big problem: Figuring out what the mass audience wants.

"I personally feel that making a Hindi film is the most difficult," Devgn said. Unlike regional cinema, which can speak to a more familiar audience and its tastes, Hindi cinema must connect with urban India, towns, suburbs and viewers whose preferences differ sharply.

"How do you get across to everybody?"

National award-winning filmmaker Shoojit Sircar said he hasn't figured it out either, when *businessline* asked the *Piku*, *Vicky Donor* and *Sardar Udham* director how filmmakers should navigate the splinter in audiences across geography, languages, theatres and streaming.

There is nearly ₹59,000 crore riding on finding that viewer.

Bollywood studios are backing films and franchises. Streaming platforms are investing in premium series. Investors are financing cheaper microdramas. And AI promises to multiply the amount of content that can be produced and tested. Their economics differ, but all are chasing the same finite resource: The Indian viewer's attention.

FINDING WHAT TRAVELS

As viewership fragments, creators are finding that stories may travel farther by becoming more specific, not more generic.

Sircar points to Satyajit Ray, who made films in Kolkata without trying to manufacture an "international" film, yet became a global reference point. "Film is not a stock market; it's someone's love, someone's passion," Sircar said.

Chef and filmmaker Ranveer Brar offered a culinary version: "A *dosa* does not become more global by becoming less south Indian. We become more global by becoming more Indian."

Netflix India Vice-President for Content Monika Shergill arrived at much the same place. "Scale becomes a prison to ideas," she said, arguing that specificity, emotional depth and a strong creator's point of view could help stories travel.

If authenticity is one way of reaching an unpredictable audience, another is to make more attempts at finding it.

COST OF EXPERIMENTATION

Online video has grown into an estimated $6-billion market in 2026, against television's $4.8 billion, according to consulting firm Media Partners Asia.

Monthly online video audience has reached 664.9 million, while connected TV reaches 206.9 million. MPA Chief Executive Vivek Couto estimates that roughly $2.6 billion is being invested in online video content.

Microdramas radically lower the cost of testing audience approval. It costs ₹15-20 lakh to produce a microdrama, against ₹2-5 crore for a premium web series.

The business models differ, too. Premium streaming uses shows to acquire and retain subscribers, and potentially build intellectual property. Microdrama platforms can find viewers through social feeds and monetise by charging for watching an episode beyond the initial teaser.

Among the 2,000 microdrama viewers aged 18-44 surveyed by Meta and Ormax, 89 per cent had discovered the format through social feeds. The study doesn't establish how many paid subsequently or became regular viewers. Kuku TV Senior Vice-President Jhoomer Sinha described the challenge as turning discovery into a daily habit.

Capital is following. Kuku Technologies, parent of Kuku TV and Kuku FM, received SEBI approval in September for its proposed IPO. Street estimates indicate a ₹2,500-3,500 crore issue and a valuation of around ₹15,000 crore.

AI IN THE MIX

JioStar's *Tadka* microdrama, offered on JioHotstar, has crossed 100 million users and has more than 100 originals.

The company says daily watch time per viewer increased five-fold during the launch phase, though it hasn't disclosed whether there is sustained retention or revenue.

AI could further lower the cost of experimentation by accelerating production and testing. Saurabh Pandey, Founder of Eloelo Group, the parent of StoryTV, said the company is producing around 100 shows a month and foresees demand for 250. It is using Dolphin AI to speed up production.

Pandey sees potential for unlimited content production, while insisting the human creator remains in the driving seat.

But unlimited content needs someone to watch it.

Prime Video is approaching the problem differently with shows such as *Panchayat* and *Dupahiya*, building distinctive worlds and characters that give viewers a reason to return. Prime Video India Subscription Video Head Shilangi Mukherji said the commercial test is whether a story could acquire customers, keep them engaged and ultimately develop into enduring IP or franchise.

AUDIENCES WHO RETURN

Bollywood is confronting the audience puzzle from another direction: Finding distinctive stories that can draw viewers and, in some cases, become intellectual property they return to.

Maddock Films Founder-Producer Dinesh Vijan illustrates just how wide the search can run. At one end is *Stree*, the Hindi horror-comedy starring Rajkummar Rao and rooted in local folklore and a small-town setting, which Maddock has developed into a larger interconnected film universe with *Stree3* to release by the end of 2028.

At the other end is the forthcoming *Prahaar*, also starring Rao but drawn from real life. Centred on public prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam, it revisits some of India's defining criminal trials, including cases arising from the 1993 Mumbai blasts and the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks.

The subjects could hardly be more different, yet they point to the same creative instinct that ran through much of the conversation at Ficci FRAMES: Stories may travel not by trying to mean something to everybody, but by being unmistakably about someone, somewhere. Actor Ayushmann Khurrana put it simply: "A story can begin in a small town in India and find an audience anywhere in the world."

Perhaps that is the twist in India's audience puzzle — making something distinctive enough that somebody will watch, pay and come back.

◉ NEW ORDER

Re-learning branding code for a fluid generation

Giraj Sharma



ANATOMY OF A PROTEST. What Gen Z wants or not PTI

Few would have imagined that student protests over a fragile examination system and paper leaks would escalate so dramatically. Beginning in June, the two-month-long agitation at Delhi's Jantar Mantar toppled an Education Minister and jolted a complacent government. And the unrest continues, with widespread protests calling for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation over the controversial Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Yet the deeper shock is generational. Baby boomers, Gen X and Millennials are realising how little they grasp Gen Z's mindset, aspiration and attitude.

Society shifts. Culture evolves. Marketers are supposed to have the knack to adapt to changes. Generational transitions aren't new, but the speed, scale and unfamiliarity of this one has left even veteran marketers and consumer behaviour experts unsettled.

The disruption caused by Gen Z drove the Marketing Academy's Discussion & Debate (MADD) — an informal forum for marketers, researchers and advertisers — to exchange ideas and explore whether the old rules of branding are dead when it comes to Gen Z.

The general consensus at MADD was that brands are struggling to decode Gen Z.

In their eagerness, some strayed from their core identity and pretended to be 'friends' with Gen Z only to be met with rejection. For this generation, such efforts feel inauthentic, even cringe. Authenticity is non-negotiable, as it always was, but with this generation the rejection is instantaneous.

The challenge for marketers is to not mimic Gen Z but engage with them meaningfully while staying true to their own DNA. A brand can remain traditional, yet resonate with Gen Z if it connects with honesty, relevance, transparency and respect.

Gen Z want brands to be authentic not only in what they say but also how they behave. They care about ethical choices: no child labour, environmental responsibility, no animal cruelty and greater transparency. Brands are expected to make these commitments visible across labels, packaging, websites and social media.

WHERE DO YOU MEET THEM?

Now here's a paradox. Gen Z may live on social media, but they don't want brands living in their space. Brand communication must be interesting and informative without becoming intrusive — stay relevant without appearing to be relentless. Social media may be public, but for Gen Z it is their very personal space. Brands have started using algorithms and programmatic advertising to target Gen Z with greater accuracy than before, but this may have started to feel like surveillance, making Gen Z uncomfortable rather than connected.

The new order apparently has demolished social hierarchies and tradition. Legacy means little. There was a time until recently when brands stood as pillars of authority. Gen Z today is fuelling the collapse of collective authority itself. No one can pinpoint when they became a cohort, but they are connected and self-aware in ways Gen X and Millennials never experienced. This cohesion is unprecedented and leading to tremors.

A CULTURAL PHENOMENON

Some veterans also argued that Gen Z is overhyped when its merely a sub-culture amplified by media overload and, perhaps, Big Tech's vested interest. Generational shifts have happened before. This one, they argued, demands adaptation, not overreaction. For them, the old rules of branding aren't dead but being rewritten. We need to treat Gen Z as a cultural phenomenon and not a demographic.

The way to capturing Gen Z's consciousness is not to manufacture stories or chase trends, but build consistent, credible evidence of what the brand stands for — evidence that surfaces naturally in search, reviews, social conversations and, increasingly, AI-generated answers.

Yet another view was that, for decades, marketers assumed that the brand is the centre of the universe of its consumers. However, Gen Z doesn't live in a brand-centric world. They live in algorithmic culture, creator-driven ecosystems and identity loops that shift every week. Marketers may keep asking: "What does our brand stand for?" Gen Z asks: "Where does your brand belong in my world today?"

Conventional branding rules were built for a stable consumer identity. But Gen Z's identity is fluid — remixable, mood-based, cohort-based and platform-shaped. Audacious as it may sound, it is more likely that Gen Z doesn't follow brands but allows brands to follow them, that too selectively. Branding isn't dead, but the consumer it was built for has gone extinct. And unless we redesign branding for a world where identity is fluid and culture moves at algorithmic speed, we're not talking to Gen Z; we're talking to ghosts!

The writer is a brand consultant and the co-founder of MADD. This piece summarises the 38th edition of MADD held at Haworth, Gurugram, and captures the views of B Narayanaswamy, Lloyd Mathias, Namrata, Naresh Gupta, Sandip Ghose, Sanjay Sarma, Sanjeev Malhotra, Shekhar Nerala, Sushreeta, Tejasvi, Ved Shukla, Vivek Anand, Vivek Srivastava and Vivasvaan Srivastava

How Mark Rothko beat the Instagram algorithm

In an online world full of noise and movement, a field of flat colour is the ultimate algorithm-breaking trap

DIGITAL GADFLY



SHUBHO SENGUPTA

For the last few weeks, I have been trying to understand the social media algorithm. I have been reading Dan Koe on the attention economy and Kane Kallaway on virality. I started wondering what would be the perfect example of the algorithm. Something that demonstrates the logic of the machine itself.

And then I realised it might be the long dead American abstract painter Mark Rothko. The Rothko viral trend on Instagram, that is.

Which is strange, because Rothko seems to be everything the algorithm should dislike. His paintings are large, quiet and slow. There are no faces, no plot, no action. Often there are just blobs, rectangles of colour, floating into one another.

Yet Rothko has become a social media phenomenon. His paintings are being turned into outfits, personalities, playlists and memes. Creators are assigning moods and identities to individual Rothkos.

The algorithm doesn't see content

The mistake is to think the algorithm rewards a particular kind of content.

Okay, it doesn't really know whether something is a Rothko painting, a cat video or a political rant. It watches behaviour.



BRUSH WITH VIRALITY. Mark Rothko's trending rectangles BLOOMBERG

Do people stop? Do they stay? Do they react? Do they share? Do they return? The definition: A machine for measuring attention.

And Rothko turns out to be very good at attracting it. Put a Rothko into an Instagram feed and it looks almost wrong. We are used to faces, movement, food, travel and people talking into cameras. There is suddenly a large field of colour. It is recognisable, but different enough to interrupt the visual flow.

Then Rothko makes you stay

This is where Rothko becomes more interesting. Stay with the painting and colours begin to shift. Edges become uncertain. The apparently flat surface acquires depth. Rothko captures attention and then removes stimulation.

Then comes emotion. Rothko didn't tell the viewer what to feel. A Rothko can be melancholy to one person and peaceful to another. The viewer supplies the missing meaning.

So it becomes: Which Rothko are you? A colour combination becomes a mood, a personality, a wardrobe, even a soundtrack. The artwork becomes a piece of identity.

The painting becomes a format

It made me think about Indian abstraction too. VS Gaitonde is an obvious reference, although I wouldn't call him an Indian Rothko. But his luminous, layered, non-objective paintings possess the quality of making the viewer stop. Nasreen Mohamedi offers another example — lines, grids and space. Her work seems incompatible with Instagram's visual excess, yet its language is extraordinarily distinctive.

We now live in an algorithmic culture. Once, media was one-way: Newspapers wrote, television broadcast, publishers published and the audience received. Today, the distance between making, distributing and consuming has disappeared.

A news story is clipped, commented upon and reframed. A brand campaign is remixed by its audience. The algorithm learns from these reactions and feeds them forward. The audience is no longer simply receiving media — it is helping make it, shape it and give it meaning.

The audience has become the medium. As Marshall McLuhan said — sometime in the 1950s — the medium is the message.

Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past

◉ STORAGE SATELLITE



PROJECT SUNCATCHER. Google scientists testing TPU chips in a vacuum chamber, simulating space conditions

The orbital data centre gambit

M Ramesh

On October 1, the SpaceX Transporter-18 rocket carried two interesting satellites (among many).

One belonged to Google, a prototype satellite under its Project Suncatcher. It carried a bunch of tensor processing units (TPUs) — specialised computer chips designed to accelerate the calculations used in artificial intelligence, particularly machine learning — to find out how they behave in the harsh conditions of space.

The other noteworthy passenger on the SpaceX rocket belonged to Hyderabad-based TakeMe2Space.

Both Google and TakeMe2Space are hoping to build orbital data centres — a moonshot which today is more an intellectual engagement, and far from commercial reality.

Data centres in space are being examined for their putative advantages — avoid using up land (especially in the context of the "not in my backyard" protests) and water, which truly is the biggest negative in terrestrial data centres.

But space data centres have to brave many other challenges. Unlike generally believed, the cold conditions in space are no advantage, because you have no convective agents like wind or liquid to dissipate the heat, leaving 'radiation' as the only option. Radiating out energy calls for specialised equipment.

It is also believed there is abundant sunshine that solar panels could convert into electricity to run equipment, but it comes with a big price tag.

Then there is the big question of bandwidth. You need to beam down to earth billions of terabytes of data using limited bandwidth. Further, today's satellites are endowed with some edge computing abilities. This means they can process some of the data before beaming it down, which takes away the big advantage of space data centres. So, if you do not (yet) look at it as a business R&D but a science quest, there is plenty to be excited about.

Take space cooling, for instance. "TPUs generate a large amount of heat in a small area, which needs to be diffused safely or the chips are at risk of overheating," says Google. But in space, there's no airflow. In a vacuum, you can only diffuse heat via radiators, which requires a totally different approach to cooling electronics. "We're working on a number of different approaches for this, including a combination of heat pipes and radiators to cool the chips," Google says. Simulations have been encouraging; the real test is underway, about 650 km above earth.

Satellite interconnection will be another interesting study. "Future designs of our satellites will each carry dozens of TPU chips while orbiting the earth in clusters. To maintain the bandwidth necessary to process AI, every satellite has to know both its own position and where it sits relative to its neighbours. To do this, satellites will communicate via lasers," says Google. Such communication is not easy. As Google notes, it is like "hitting a coin-sized target from miles away, while both points are in motion". Google will test this in 2027.

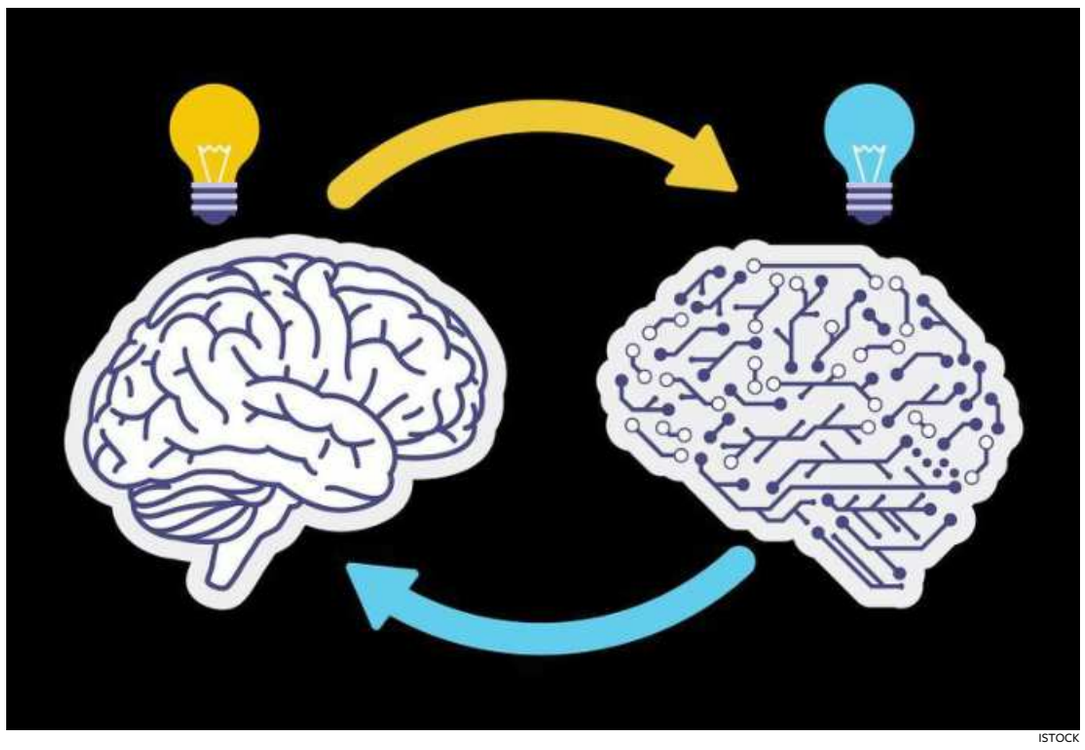
The scientific world, more than the commercial world, will be watching Project Suncatcher to see how Google gets a touch of the sun.

◉ HUMAN-AI TETE-A-TETE

The heads that look like ours

ABSTRACT REASONING. A match with brain data tells you where a model looks, and little about how it answers

N Nagaraj



ISTOCK

Read this sequence: Hat, hat, hat, risk, hat, hat, hat. What comes next?

Most people say "risk". The pattern is three of one word, one different word, three more of the first, and then the different word again. Volunteers at the University of Amsterdam solved puzzles of this kind in an earlier experiment ('Large language models show signs of alignment with human neurocognition during abstract reasoning', by Pinier et al), using icons instead of words, wearing caps that recorded the electrical activity of their brain while cameras tracked their eyes. Language models were given a text version of the same puzzles.

Researchers from Amsterdam and Princeton ('Which attention heads are like the human head? Not the ones that compute', by Pinier and Opiełka) have now used the data to ask a pointed question. Some parts of an AI model behave like the human brain on this task. Are those the parts doing the work?

Mostly, no. The question matters because resemblance is a common kind of evidence that AI systems work like brains.

When a unit in a model responds in a pattern that resembles a brain recording, the result is called alignment, and it is often read as a sign that the two compute something in common. The authors say the direct test had not been done: Rank units by alignment, remove them and measure the model on the same task.

The researchers studied attention heads — small components that decide which earlier words a model looks at while preparing its next word. Each head received a brain score, which asks whether the manner in which its responses differ across the eight pattern types matches the human recordings, and a causal score, which asks to what extent restoring its normal activity helps the model answer correctly. They deleted heads in the order of each score, highest first, and compared the damage with deleting the same number at random.

WHAT HAPPENED

Deleting the causally important heads did the most damage. In the main model, a large Llama, removing a small fraction took accuracy from about seven in 10 below the level of guessing. Deleting the most brain-like heads stayed close to what random deletion did. Across 17 models, brain-ranked deletions usually hurt more than random ones, so these heads carry some load, but far less than the causal ones. Ranked by brain resemblance and by causal importance, the heads fall in almost unrelated orders.

Among the brain-like heads, the researchers found two recurring habits of attention: One favours repeated words, the other the odd one out, the lone "risk" among the hats.

The authors call them repetition and novelty heads — names that describe where the heads look and claim no function. Novelty heads tracked human gaze in every model. Once each position's average is removed from both, their attention moved from pattern to pattern the way people's eyes did. Yet removing about a sixth of the main model's heads in order of novelty left it solving most puzzles, while removing the same number at random pulled it below half.

There is a catch. In most of the puzzle types, the odd word is also the answer, and the match between gaze and heads sits mostly there, so the data cannot say whether people and models are drawn to the word because it is odd or because it is the answer. The heads that do the work look at it too, so where a head looks does not show whether the head is working.

The authors offer one possible explanation: Every head must spread its attention somewhere, whether or not its output matters, so a recognisable habit can appear as a byproduct. Biologists call such features spandrels, after the decorated spaces between cathedral arches.

WHAT THE STUDY CAN'T SAY

The work rests on one task with eight pattern types and one set of recordings from the front of the scalp, in a preprint not yet reviewed by other scientists. "Brain alignment" here means resemblance to that single recording.

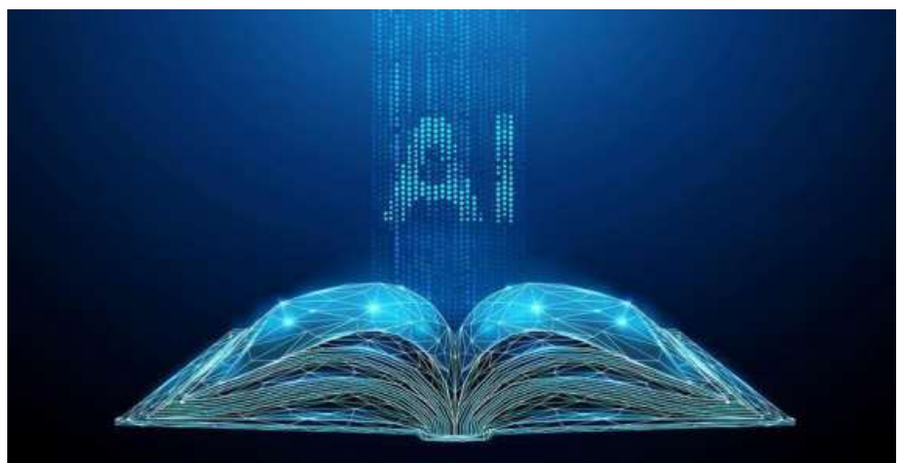
The novelty result is less tidy than it looks: In the appendix, novelty-like heads chosen to sit in the same layers as the repetition heads cost more accuracy when deleted than the repetition heads did.

WHY IT MATTERS

The finding shows that resemblance can fail to predict function here. A match with brain data told the researchers how the model reads the puzzle and, in the authors' account, said little about how it forms the pattern or finds the answer. For scientists who use models to study the brain, and for anyone weighing a claim that a model thinks like us, a fair question is whether anyone removed the matching parts and saw what happened.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

◉ WOW. The all-seeing AI



M Ramesh

A coded, secret wartime letter. Over two centuries old. It was a hearteningly baffling mystery — until AI made light of it.

It was written and sent by Eugène de Beauharnais, a stepson of Napoleon, to General Auguste de Marmont, informing him of the Napoleonic forces arrayed against the enemy — Austria. The letter was preserved, but not the code. So it remained undeciphered for 217 years.

Carter Church, an AI engineer at cybersecurity company SentinelOne, used OpenAI's GPT-6 Astra to decipher the coded military message.

The letter was a cryptographer's nightmare. It contained about 1,300 coded elements, made up of 155 different signs. A historian had identified the meaning of 33 symbols, but it still left much of the message shrouded in secrecy.

But GPT-6 Astra, as one can imagine, laughed lightly at it. It handed Church the neat English version in six hours. Astra first read the handwriting, then connected the letter to an existing partial code table. It went on to develop a computational method, called 'Simulated annealing', testing possible symbol values against patterns in the French language. Historical writings helped check whether the resulting text made sense. Its achievement went beyond unlocking an old message. It signified the triumph of the collaboration of handwriting recognition, historical research, cryptanalysis and computer programming in one workflow.

"This is a really interesting use of artificial intelligence... to try and provide a credible solution to a historical mystery," Zack White, a history research fellow at the University of Portsmouth and the host of the *Napoleonic Wars Podcast*, told Live Science.

◉ ADAPTABLE POWER SUPPLY

Fine-tuned electrolysis

M Ramesh

Researchers at the Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, have developed a reconfigurable power conversion system for electrified hydrogen generation. The system improves the efficiency, power quality and reliability of the electrolysers.

Electrolysis requires a large amount of electrical power, and the quality of the power supply directly affects the quantity of hydrogen produced.

Electricity supplied from the grid or other power sources must first be converted from AC to DC and then regulated in terms of voltage, current and so on through a power conversion system.

High-power electrolyser systems often use multiple parallel power converter sections/channels to handle the large current used, but this leads to reduced efficiency, current and voltage fluctuations, unequal current sharing among the power converter sections/channels, and a slower response to changes in system operating conditions. These issues can also affect the quality of power drawn from an electrical source.

A major challenge arises because electrolysers do not always operate at their rated electrical power. Their power requirement can vary, depending on hydrogen production and the availability or operating conditions of the electrical power source. This is called 'partial-load operation', where only a required number of sections/channels are activated based on operating power.

However, deciding which sections to operate and coordinating them is important to ensure that efficiency is improved without compromising on the power supply to the electrolyser.

The IIT-Madras team — led by Dr Deepak Ronanki, Assistant Professor, Department of Engineering Design — has developed a new power conversion system that can adapt to changing hydrogen production requirements and operating conditions of the electrical power source. It consists of multiple sections/channels that can be individually switched on or off.

The researchers have developed a predictive control framework assisted by a reconfiguration strategy (which gives the number of sections/channels to be operated without comprising performance). The framework ensures that the current is properly shared between the active sections, while reducing fluctuations in the power supplied to the electrolyser. This enables the system to respond quickly when the operating conditions change.

"The architecture allows for the activation or deactivation of individual converter channels," Ronanki told *businessline*. This potentially reduces conversion losses while maintaining the electrical performance.

An important feature is the ability to continue operating even if one of the converter sections/channels becomes unavailable. This improves the reliability of the overall system and reduces the impact of failures and downtime.

The system was first evaluated through simulations and subsequently validated experimentally using a 5 kVA laboratory prototype.

Overall, the research provides a solution that allows electrolyser systems to efficiently adapt to changing requirements while maintaining good electrical power quality drawn form source, fewer fluctuations, fast response to changes in system operating conditions, and reliable operation.

SCALE-UP CHALLENGE

On the challenges in scaling up, Ronanki pointed to technical wrinkles that need to be ironed out. At megawatt scale, the power conversion system must handle thousands of amperes. This forces the use of many parallel converter sections/channels. Therefore, the cooling system and thermal management become crucial. Also, the need to make it compact proves a major design constraint. This is because, at high power, the converter interacts strongly with the electrical power source.

A reconfiguration strategy that switches sections on and off may introduce additional harmonic content (power fluctuations on the electrical source side), so the power converter system must be carefully designed and controlled to ensure compliance with standards.

Ronanki said the design includes the ability to continue operating if one converter section fails. "At scale, the system may contain a greater number of parallel sections/channels," he said, cautioning, however, that coordinating fault detection, isolation and reconfiguration across so many sections in real time is a significant challenge, which needs further investigation.

The proposed power conversion system also has the potential to reduce operating costs by improving energy utilisation. However, the overall cost, including equipment, maintenance and long-term operation, may need to be evaluated further as the technology is scaled up to higher power ratings, Ronanki said.



POWER EQUATION. In electrolysis, the quality of electricity affects the quantity of hydrogen produced ISTOCK

A delicious cuppa decided by electrochemistry

New coffee testing technology measures beverage strength and roast intensity in one go

K Bharat Kumar

"As long as there was coffee in the world, how bad can things be?" asked American author Cassandra Clare. And if you are a true connoisseur of the beverage, you would likely agree.

But as much as a cup of great coffee can lift your spirits, a bad brew can crush it. How do coffee roasteries and brewers get it just right?

Beverage strength and the degree of roast determine flavour and, hence, commercial value. Optical refractometers can measure coffee concentration, namely the quantum of dissolved solids, but cannot differentiate between a light and dark roast, Arabica and Robusta varieties, and washed and natural processing.

What is the alternative?

Enter cyclic voltammetry (CV), an age-old principle in electrochemical science that helps observe molecular behaviour as they add or shed electrons.



ISTOCK

A paper published earlier this year by researchers at the University of Oregon and Drexel University demonstrated this simpler method for coffee testing.

Instead of adding chemical reagents or sending samples through lengthy lab processes, researchers dipped a platinum electrode directly into a cup of fresh, undiluted black coffee. Brewed coffee is naturally conductive — it can pass a current between electrodes. Moreover, its pH remains steady no matter how long current flows through it, a property called self-buffering.

Both these properties are critical when assessing quality. Voltage changes induce electrochemical reactions at the electrode's surface, causing a small current to flow. By measuring how this current rises and falls, the researchers could quickly determine the liquid's chemical composition.

"I thought it was a very beautiful concept," says Sunalini Menon, President of Coffelabs Ltd and a board member of the Specialty Coffee Alliance.

DATA POINTS IN A SHOT

Menon says a traditional roastery or lab must use an optical refractometer to measure beverage strength and an Agtron colour meter to gauge roast darkness. Cyclic voltammetry combines both in a single device. When electric potential is applied, the initial surge of current measures the movement of free protons in the liquid, which indicates the strength of the brew. Alongside this, key organic molecules in the coffee, such as caffeine and chlorogenic acids, adhere to the platinum electrode surface. The speed and degree of the coating, which suppresses the current, indicate the roast level and chemical composition of the liquid.

Further, optical refractometers and colour meters record only surface reflection and cannot tell whether a roasted bean may be undercooked inside. CVs can detect this — the undercooked parts change the coffee's organic chemistry and, thereby, the coating on the electrode, which helps flag a less-than-perfect batch.

The cost of a CV is on the higher side, hindering widespread adoption. However, large roasteries, speciality brands and quality labs stand to benefit by consolidating two instruments into one automated and more accurate chemical readout.

As Menon recalls, "In my tenure at the Coffee Board of India in 1985, we introduced the Washed Robusta. There was initial high resistance, but ultimately it helped elevate Indian Robusta to world-class status."

New concepts such as CVs may help push the envelope further.

GLOBAL BYTES.

Ethiopian Airlines' new Boeing orders

Boeing and Ethiopian Airlines have announced that the African carrier has ordered eight 777-8 freighters and two 777 freighters. The airline will pair the proven performance of the 777 freighter with the next-generation 777X capabilities of the new 777-8 freighter to expand its Boeing freighter fleet, it said in a statement.



The order is Ethiopian Airlines' second for the 777X airplane family, after its purchase of eight 777-9 passenger jets established the carrier as Africa's first 777X customer. The 777-8 will be the world's largest and most capable twin-engine freighter, supporting Ethiopian Airlines' expanding global network and advancing its international freight operations, the statement added.

MOL-Vale deal for tri-fuel ore carriers

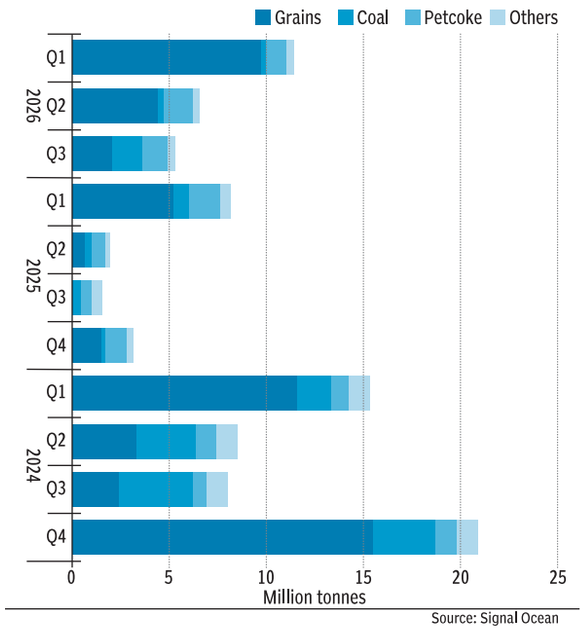
MOL Ocean Bulk Pte Ltd, which operates the MOL Group's overseas capesize bulker business, has signed a 25-year contract with Vale International SA (a subsidiary of Vale SA) to transport iron ore using two vessels.



As part of Vale's shipping decarbonisation strategy, the project will employ the world's first 210,000-tonne ore carriers equipped with a tri-fuel propulsion system that can run on ethanol, methanol and conventional heavy fuel oil. The vessels are scheduled for delivery in 2030. They also feature an LNG/ammonia-ready design, enabling the future use of either fuel. By providing flexibility in fuel selection according to fuel availability, decarbonisation benefits and economic considerations, the vessels broaden the options for reducing greenhouse gas emissions in marine transport, a company statement said.

Rivals bond over cargo

US dry bulk shipments to China jump 104% as trade relations improve



Source: Signal Ocean

RE POSTS.

India enters the Mega Port era.
India's maritime sector marks another landmark achievement.
Deendayal (Kandla), Jawaharlal Nehru (Nhava Sheva), Paradip and Mundra have been notified as Mega Ports under the Indian Ports Act, 2025.
This recognition reflects their scale, capacity and strategic role in driving trade, strengthening logistics efficiency and supporting economic growth.
A new chapter in India's maritime journey begins — the era of Mega Ports.

Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
@shipmin_india

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload



Truck route	Rentals as on Sep 17	Rentals as on Oct 1	% change
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,76,000	1,77,000	0.56
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,81,000	1,82,000	0.55
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,97,000	1,98,000	0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,06,000	2,07,000	0.48
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,21,000	2,20,000	-0.45
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,30,000	2,31,000	0.43
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,76,000	1,77,000	0.56
Delhi–Raipur-Delhi	1,70,000	1,71,000	0.58
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,45,000	1,46,000	0.68
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,76,000	1,75,000	-0.57
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,06,000	2,07,000	0.48
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,06,000	2,07,000	0.48
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,15,000	2,16,000	0.46
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,20,000	2,19,000	-0.46
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,51,000	1,52,000	0.66
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,86,000	2,88,000	0.69
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,88,000	2,87,000	-0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,72,000	1,73,000	0.58
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,51,000	1,52,000	0.66
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,06,000	1,07,000	0.93
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,69,000	1,68,000	-0.60
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,58,000	1,59,000	0.63
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,21,000	1,20,000	-0.83
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	76,000	77,000	1.30
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	87,000	88,000	1.14
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	75,000	74,000	-1.35

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

◉ MISSION SAMUDRA

Keralam eyes port-led economic rise

SEA OF OPPORTUNITY. State's ₹400-crore project aims to create an integrated logistics hub centred on maritime strengths

V Sajeev Kumar



WORK IN PROGRESS. The Vizhinjam seaport lacks a container freight station, a multimodal logistics park and empty container yard PTI

The Keralam government's five-year Mission Samudra initiative seeks to transform the State into a global maritime and economic hub through the development of an integrated logistics ecosystem revolving around its ports.

Announced in the State's revised budget for 2026–27, the project will run from 2026–31, bringing together 12 departments and all major State maritime agencies under a common governance framework.

According to Chief Minister VD Satheesan, Mission Samudra will focus on developing not just ports but also the entire State economy through its maritime strengths. With an allocation of ₹400 crore, the project will tap Kerala's 600-km coastline and its maritime history, including the ancient Muziris trade links, to promote economic growth.

More than the number of ships calling at the State's ports or containers handled at terminals, the real success of the project must be measured by the opportunities it creates for the State's people, the government said. "The sea before us is not the boundary. It is Keralam's gateway to the world. And through Mission Samudra, we intend to open that gateway — responsibly, sustainably and inclusively — for a new generation," the Chief Minister said.

INTEGRATED STRENGTHS

The rise of the Vizhinjam International Seaport has positioned Keralam at the intersection of major global trade and logistics networks. "Our objective is to integrate the State's coastline, international ports, container transshipment infrastructure, non-major ports and water resources with road, rail and inland waterway connectivity, industries, logistics and new economic centres," Satheesan said.

Rathan U Kelkar, Secretary, Ports Department, said Mission Samudra will leverage the emergence of Vizhinjam as a major transshipment hub, as also the State's strong network of ports and airports.

The wider ecosystem will include multimodal corridors, warehousing and distribution hubs, shipbuilding and ship repair facilities, bunkering and maritime services, coastal shipping, fisheries and seafood value chains, cruise tourism, export-oriented industries, free trade and logistics zones, and maritime skilling.

These will be complemented by Keralam's aviation hub initiative, which focuses on integrating airports, air cargo, and maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) services with the maritime network. The objective is to convert the State's exceptional sea and air connectivity into investment, industries, jobs and economic opportunities, Kelkar said.

However, the challenge lies in the fact that an ecosystem of this scale cannot be created through isolated projects. It requires coordinated planning and execution across the ports, airports, roads, railways, industry, logistics, urban development and skilling sectors, involving multiple State and central agencies as well as private investment, he said.

Land availability, last-mile connectivity, financing, regulatory and environmental clearances, and the timely creation of supporting infrastructure will be critical, he added.

The initiative assumes added significance as the Vizhinjam International Seaport is already handling cargo beyond its installed capacity of 1 million TEUs. Its throughput is projected to reach 5.7 million TEUs by 2028–29. As connectivity improves, gateway exim cargo is expected to account for 40 per cent of throughput by 2035–40, compared with the 25 per cent projected for 2029–30, translating into 2.3 million TEUs at maturity.

INFRASTRUCTURE NEEDS

However, the benefits of a transshipment port can extend beyond the terminal only when the supporting logistics infrastructure is available. Vizhinjam currently lacks a container freight station, multimodal logistics park and empty container yard. In comparison, Mundra port has 20 CFS and MMLPs spread across 1,201 acres and JNPA has 24 such facilities across 1,176 acres.

Prashant Vasisht, Senior Vice-President and Co-group Head, Corporate Ratings, ICRA Ltd, said Mission Samudra could help strengthen the State's shipping, logistics and trade network by improving port-related infrastructure, industrial facilities and transport connectivity.

Given the strategic importance of Vizhinjam and the State's coastal infrastructure, the project could support investments in logistics, warehousing, manufacturing and allied sectors over the long term. If implemented successfully, it could increase cargo handling capacity, make supply chains more efficient and support economic growth.

Land availability will be a critical factor in implementing the project. According to a preliminary estimate, nearly 2,000 acres may be required for projects, including a free trade warehousing zone and off-dock logistics facilities.

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bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

◉ AIRPORT FINANCES

Should CIAL collect user fees?



PAUL ANTONY



SOLO ACT. Kochi airport is dependent on a single runway THULASI KAKKAT

The year 2025–26 seems to have been good for Cochin International Airport Limited (CIAL), which made a record profit of ₹502 crore and, in another record, declared a dividend of 55 per cent. On a turnover of ₹1,220 crore, it implies a remarkable 41 per cent margin.

In contrast, GMR Airports Ltd, the closest peer, which operates the Delhi and Hyderabad airports, registered just 1.57 per cent profit margin.

This prompted me to take a closer look at tariff fixation at Indian airports.

Airports are capital-intensive and investors need to be fairly compensated. Accordingly, the regulator — the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) — fixes tariffs, including user development fees, based on the investments projected in the airport operator's core aeronautical activities.

In the case of CIAL, the AERA had approved an investment of ₹1,416 crore for 2022-26, and a user fee of ₹270 for domestic and ₹570 for international passengers.

During 2025-26, the user fee collected was ₹236 crore, but CIAL executed only about 40 per cent of the approved aeronautical works. The excess collection led to the record profit and dividend.

The unspent amount should, therefore, have been excluded from the profit, else CIAL should have stopped levying the user fee.

When the Kochi airport started operations in 1999, there was no AERA. CIAL collected a user fee of ₹500 per passenger and issued a receipt for it.

Today, the user fee is incorporated in the flight fare, and most passengers may not even realise they are paying it.

In 2005, the then Chief Minister Oommen Chandy discontinued the user fee when CIAL began making profits. The collection was restarted in 2022.

The user fee would attract less opposition were it earmarked for something productive, such as the construction of a second runway.

The sole runway at Kochi airport is due for re-carpeting in 2028. Once the work starts, no flights will be permitted between 10 am and 6 pm, leading to major disruptions. Yet CIAL has not made any effort to develop a second runway. As a first step, it must acquire around 300 acres.

SHAREHOLDERS' ROLE

When the issue of dividend is discussed, it is often argued that the non-resident Indian (NRI) investors who have made CIAL a reality should not be denied returns when the airport is doing well. But it would be instructive to examine how the funding was raised.

The airport was commissioned on May 25, 1999, at a cost of ₹305 crore. CIAL's equity on March 31 that year was ₹66 crore. Interest-free deposits of ₹21 crore came from service providers like Air India and the duty-free shop contractor. The rest comprised loans raised from HUDCO, the State Bank of Travancore and Federal Bank at about 18 per cent interest.

The investor directors, mostly NRIs, held equity of only ₹11 crore, or 3.61 per cent of the project cost. The private investors increased their holding only after CIAL started making profits in 2002-03.

While CIAL today has about 16,000 shareholders, about 26 per cent of the equity is held by the top three private shareholders and they alone receive ₹68 crore dividend; some would allege a conflict of interest when shareholders sit on the board, decide to collect user fees and pay dividends to themselves without executing developmental works.

It raises the question whether the CIAL should have followed the IPO route to expand its equity base.

EXPERT GUIDANCE

A related issue pertains to whether the Chief Minister and Ministers should continue to serve on the CIAL board. Once the airport became operational, they should arguably have made way for officers and other professionals to manage it.

One wonders whether it is the absence of the right expertise on the CIAL board that has led to the de-prioritisation of the second runway or the conversion of the precious T2 Terminal space next to the apron as an exclusive 40,000-sq ft 'Business Jet Terminal', which is used by very few, and the 60,000-sq ft '0484 Aero Lounge', forcing CIAL to plan for the expansion of the domestic terminal.

The manner in which the sole direct London flight to CIAL was aborted in 2025 after four years of operation at reasonable occupancy levels smacks, again, of a lack of vision. CIAL needs to decide where it sees itself in 10 years. Should it continue to remain a satellite of West Asian airports? Especially at a time when numerous airports are springing up across India, and 2,000 new aircraft orders have been placed in anticipation of a major expansion of the country's airline services.

The writer is a former Chief Secretary of Keralam

◉ FESTIVAL INVENTORY

Delivering season's joy

Rohan Das



'BOX' OFFICE. The 'packing lane' at Flipkart's fulfilment centre in Ottakkalmandapam, near Coimbatore

With the festival season in full swing, bargain hunters are on the prowl on e-commerce apps, chasing down the best deals and the lowest prices. Amidst all the marketing and shopping frenzy, here's a look at how millions of packages are collected, managed and delivered seamlessly across the length and breadth of the country during the high-demand season.

At Flipkart's 1.2 lakh sq ft fulfilment centre in Ottakkalmandapam, near Coimbatore, which is focused on mobiles, electronics and general merchandise, a combination of people, process and technology does the trick.

After being unloaded at various docks, the stock arriving from different corners of the country travels on a conveyor belt to the inbound zone.

Here, Anjana (name changed), after ensuring all the attributes match as advertised, sticks a warehouse ID (WID) on each item. The little barcode essentially becomes the means through which the item is tracked until it reaches the customer's doorstep.

AUTOMATED HANDLERS

The ID'd products are moved to the facility's four-storey storage section. Equipped with handled scanners — the likely hero of the operation — 'putters' scan and place the new stock in the designated shelf while 'pickers' lift the sold products off the shelf and place them in blue tod boxes. As soon as a putter scans a product, it becomes available for customers to purchase on the app.

"They (staff) do not have to worry where to put and what to pick. It's all managed through a centralised system. The low-demand ones at the top floors, the high-demand ones at the centre of the aisle — it is all pre-decided," says the facility manager.

In fact, the computerised system even measures the size, weight and volume of each item, calculates which of them can fit in one tod and sends the info to the pickers' scanner.

In the packing section, the system tells packers which box to use, which products to club and even how much packing peanuts to add — all facilitated by the same scanners.

The packages — now in their final form with a new ID — reach the sorting station, where the scanner again tells the sorters where each box will go.

After multiple sorting stages based on the city, secondary fulfilment centres and final delivery hubs involved — all managed through the computerised system and scanners — the packages, now in bags, return to the docks to be ferried to the delivery hubs.

For the festival season, Flipkart has expanded its fulfilment network to handle the expected surge in orders. The company's logistics arm Ekart has added 14 million cubic ft, or 50 per cent more warehousing space, while extending its delivery footprint to more than 750 new PIN codes. It has also added over 900 delivery hubs, taking the total to 8,200 across the country.

Hemant Badri, Senior Vice-President and Head of Supply Chain, Flipkart Group, said the densification of the logistics network had helped reduce the impact of rising fuel and packaging costs.

"For large appliances, we have doubled the number of fulfilment centres to 40 and cut the average distance travelled from about 290 km to 150 km. We keep solving through design and going closer to the customer," he added.

The writer was in Coimbatore at Flipkart's invitation

MY FIVE.



AJAY DD SINGHANIA
Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, EPACK Durable Limited

Five elements — from manifesting to yoga and disconnecting

1 **Meditation — Akasha:** My day begins at 5 am with a few quiet minutes of manifestation, visualising the day ahead, followed by meditation before the world wakes up. The pause creates the mental space needed before the day's pace picks up. It helps me respond with clarity rather than react, bringing greater perspective, patience and judgment to every decision.

2 **Yoga — Prithvi:** Meditation flows naturally into yoga — keeps me physically disciplined and mentally grounded before work. I practise every morning with my personal instructor, and the daily commitment helps me stay consistent, focused and balanced.

3 **Reading — Vayu:** Reading is my way of learning and staying curious — books on business, self-development, technology and autobiographies. Even short reading breaks give me a fresh perspective.

4 **Eating well — Agni:** Good health is built through consistency, not extremes. As a vegetarian, I prefer simple, home-cooked meals with balanced portions. No fad diets — just mindful eating that keeps me energised through long workdays.

5 **Evenings — Jal:** End the day at a slower pace. Before calling it a night, I spend some quiet time with my family and often read a few pages of a book. It helps disconnect from work, reflect on the day and prepare for the next one with a calm mind.

CAPSULE.

Mass gatherings see rise in heat-related illnesses



Heat-related illness at mass gatherings, such as major sporting, religious or cultural events, has become a significant public health and operational risk, affecting spectators, attendees, volunteers and workers, said the World Health Organization. But most heat-related illnesses can be prevented or treated on site through timely risk management measures, it added, citing recently published data.

"Extreme heat is an increasing threat to health, safety and operational continuity in mass gatherings, and must be addressed not only as an environmental hazard but also a core operational and governance challenge," said Dr Chikwe Ihekweazu, Executive Director, WHO Health Emergencies Programme. There has been an estimated 63 per cent increase in heat-related deaths since the 1990s, with an average of 5,46,000 deaths occurring annually between 2012 and 2021, the UN health agency said. Mass gatherings can amplify heat risks in several ways. Long periods outdoors with exposure to heat and sun, dense crowds, limited access to safe water and travel-related stress can combine to create dangerous conditions, it said.

COMING UP.

Real voices on mental health

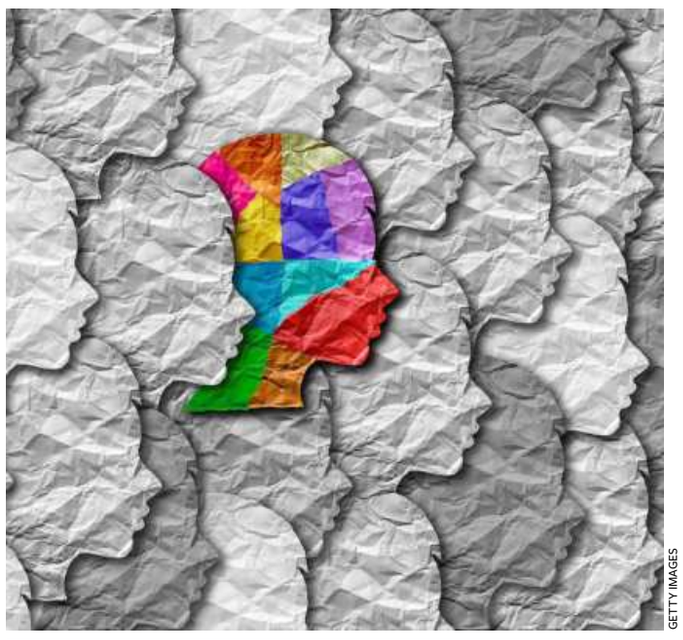
World Mental Health Day (October 10) is an opportunity to engage with 'people with lived experience' (PWLE) of mental health conditions and to recognise their knowledge as a vital form of expertise, says the WHO. This year's campaign calls for their voices to shape the policies, services and decisions that affect their lives.

BEYOND LISTING

Social entrepreneurs: Putting money where their heart is

IMPACT INVESTING. What is special about a public issue by a neurodivergence care service

KS Badri Narayanan



GETTY IMAGES

When Rays of Belief Ltd tapped the capital market last month to fund its expansion, the ₹125-crore public issue marked a significant milestone in India's impact investing landscape. It created the country's first listed for-profit social enterprise and healthcare provider focused exclusively on children with autism.

Raising funds through stock exchanges for social causes remains relatively uncommon. Yet both the BSE and the NSE have established Social Stock Exchanges to facilitate this, with several NGOs, including Sightsavers India, already benefiting. But will investors actually put their money where their heart is?

Against this backdrop, eight-year-old Rays of Belief, which operates through its Mom's Belief brand, stands out: It focuses on neuro-developmental disorders (NDDs), one of the most nuanced and critical areas of healthcare. Autism spectrum disorder (ASD) is one such complex developmental condition that affects an individual's cognitive processes, behaviour and social interactions.

The company's first multi-disciplinary centre came up in Gurugram in 2018, and today it has 136 centres across the country. It expanded overseas through the acquisition of three centres in Virginia, USA. The services include early intervention, occupational and language therapy, parental guidance and family support.

Pointing to the absence of a precedent, the company says in its IPO documents that investors may find it difficult to evaluate the business, its financial performance and future prospects, especially against industry benchmarks. Nevertheless, the IPO attracted an enthusiastic response and was subscribed nearly 108 times. However, its post-listing performance is underwhelming — from ₹239, the stock now hovers around ₹230.

The company's latest first quarter results showed a net profit of ₹2.79 crore against a net loss of ₹53.7 lakh during the same period last fiscal, thanks to the rapid scaling up of its specialised centres internationally, and robust operating leverage. Revenue grew 136.45 per cent to ₹25.31 crore. What value do these numbers hold for the community the venture caters to?

Raghuraman Sridharan, the parent of a child with special needs, admits he is not savvy enough to understand the financial workings of Rays of Belief. For him, the real value of the IPO listing lies elsewhere: If it helps spread awareness of autism and other NDDs, he would be more than happy.

He points out that many parents omit to act early, often missing a critical window for intervention. "If the problem is identified early and proper medical attention provided, then the child's developmental outcomes can improve significantly."

Highlighting a different area of concern, another parent who declined to be named, says that while awareness is important, cost matters just as much. "My only hope is that this doesn't end up driving up medical expenses for parents like me," he adds.

On the absence of adequate insurance products for such conditions, Sridharan rues, "Not many insurers offer cover for these specific needs."

At present only a handful of options exist, including the Niramaya Health Insurance Scheme, run under the National Trust, and Star Health's Star Special Care policy.

The Mom's Belief website says it, too, offers insurance coverage through a tie-up. According to its red herring prospectus, the insurance plan, underwritten by a healthcare insurance provider, was launched in February 2022 for children enrolled with the hospital. It covers hospitalisation, online and offline home therapies and OPD costs incurred for pre-existing conditions through cashless benefits and reimbursement of claims, it said, adding, "As of March 31, 2026, families of 429 children enrolled with us had availed this insurance, with 23 of them having active policies."

NDD CARE ECONOMY

According to CARE Ratings, in 2025, the market for neuro-developmental disorder (NDD) care in India stood at ₹5,262.30 crore, with autism spectrum disorder (ASD), attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) and cerebral palsy together accounting for 72.72 per cent, or ₹3,815 crore. ASD prevalence in India is estimated at 19.11 million, as of December 2025.

FUNDING NEEDS

Going ahead, this segment will get much-needed funding from private equity players, say healthcare watchers.

A report by Brown University's Center for Advancing Health Policy through Research says that private equity firms acquired more than 500 autism therapy centres across the US over the past decade, with nearly 80 per cent over a four-year span.

"The big takeaway is that there is yet another segment of health care that has emerged as potentially profitable to private equity investors, and it is very distinct from where we have traditionally known investors to go, so the potential for harm can be a lot more serious," said Yashaswini Singh, a health economist at Brown's School of Public Health, who authored the report.

FROM THE REGULATOR

Missing women in the medicine map



ISTOCK

By the year-end, the European Medicines Agency (EMA) will develop a regulatory roadmap to drive a decisive change in how women's health is considered across medicines development and regulation. This follows a two-day multi-stakeholder workshop held recently in Amsterdam, where participants converged on a series of priority actions.

While women comprise half of the world's population, persistent gaps in research, evidence generation and medicines development mean that many of their specific health needs remain insufficiently understood and addressed, contributing to poorer health outcomes and unmet medical needs.

"Women are still missing: From research and data, prevention, diagnosis and treatment. But the momentum to improve support for women's health has never been stronger. Over the last two days, we have seen what can be achieved when diverse voices unite behind a common cause. Now is the time to act. EMA will build on this dialogue to shape a roadmap on medicines for women's health that will help drive progress, in Europe and beyond," EMA Executive Director Emer Cooke said at the end of the meet.

Participants prioritised 10 proposed actions in areas where the EMA could lead, collaborate or influence. The broad consensus on the priority actions highlighted clear opportunities for change through greater global alignment.

The priority actions will feed into a roadmap on medicines for women's health, which will include concrete deliverables with planned short-, medium- and long-term timelines. The roadmap, together with the workshop report, are planned for publication by the year-end.

The actions include working together with patients and other stakeholders to identify priorities, evidence gaps and unmet needs; supporting research, including providing adequate funding, to comprehensively address evidence gaps and unmet needs; and improve the enrolment of women in clinical trials and reporting of high-quality sex disaggregated data, among others.

Source: EMA

LENS ON HEALTH



INFECTIOUS ENTHUSIASM. New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani and former New York City mayoral candidate Curtis Sliwa receive flu shots from the Commissioner of the New York City Department of Health and Mental Hygiene, Dr Alister Martin, at the Fort Greene Immunization Clinic REUTERS

Enabling breast cancer screening in remote settings

A portable, handheld device from UE LifeSciences flags abnormal findings for further evaluation

PT Jyothi Datta



ISTOCK

Come October, iconic buildings around the world are lit up in pink to spread awareness on breast cancer.

It is among the most common cancers in women globally, but inequalities persist in survival rates, says the World Health Organization. Around 70 per cent of breast cancer deaths occur in low- and middle-income countries, "where access to early detection, timely diagnosis and comprehensive treatment remains more limited", the UN health agency says.

Looking to address the need for early diagnosis, UE Lifesciences screens for abnormalities that may need follow-ups through its portable, handheld device iBreastExam.

"To create a meaningful impact, we needed a product that could actually reach primary-care settings... That thinking led to the development of iBreastExam," says Madhukumar MK, Chief Business Officer, UE LifeSciences. The product has secured regulatory approvals in over 12 countries in about 15 years.

The US-based company has subsidiaries in India and Malaysia and a manufacturing unit in Mumbai, says Madhukumar. The company was founded by Mihir Shah, Bhaumik Sanghvi and Dr Matthew Campisi, and is backed by Biocon's Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, among others.

The device uses pressure sensing technology to identify abnormalities in breast tissue density, says Madhukumar. "It differentiates between normal and abnormal tissue, and flags the abnormal findings that require further evaluation through advanced diagnostic modalities."

UNFINISHED BATTLE

An estimated 2.4 million women were diagnosed with breast cancer in 2024, of whom 6,94,000 succumbed to the disease
(Source: WHO)

PORTABILITY

"It is battery-operated and does not require an internet connection, so it can be taken to virtually any part of the world," says Madhukumar.

With the help of trained health workers, breast screenings are done at primary care settings and communities, he adds.

In Goa, for example, about 25 iBreastExam devices have helped screen more than 2,00,000 women over four years, says Madhukumar. More than 3,600 abnormalities and 93 cancer cases were detected, he says. Many of these findings may have been missed in a routine clinical examination based on hand palpation, he adds.

"Finding an abnormality is only the first step. Women need to be guided through further evaluation and treatment... The State government is part of the initiative," he explains.

The firm is developing two more products — one for cervical cancer screening and the other for oral health. These are also intended for early screening, he says.

Currently the company is scaling up the availability of iBreastExam through a distribution tie-up with Molbio Diagnostics in India, West Asia, Africa and some countries in Southeast Asia, DuoPharma in Malaysia, Siemens in the US and Biogenetech in Thailand.

Fostering equitable access to biomedical innovation

BY INVITATION



SANJAY SARIN



PUBLIC HEALTH MISSION. Drug discovery for neglected diseases ISTOCK

For decades, India has been the 'pharmacy of the developing world'. Now it is time for it to become an innovation powerhouse, transforming scientific discoveries into medicines that address the unmet health needs of millions.

Today, India supplies around 20 per cent of the world's generic medicines and ranks among the largest vaccine manufacturers globally. Its pharma industry has played a pivotal role in expanding access to affordable and quality medicines globally.

But manufacturing is only half the story. The next frontier is the discovery and development of new medicines. Many diseases that mainly affect low- and middle-income countries receive limited commercial investment because they generate little financial return. India is particularly affected by this gap. In 2023, it had around 622 million, or 41.6 per cent of the people globally in need of treatment for neglected tropical diseases (NTDs) such as dengue, mycetoma and lymphatic filariasis.

Investing in drug discovery and development for neglected diseases is, therefore, a public health imperative. It can support universal health coverage while contributing to disease elimination efforts. India has the scientific foundation to play a much larger role in drug discovery and development. Few countries combine India's demographic scale, genetic diversity and disease burden, making it an exceptional setting for developing treatments relevant to India and the wider Global South.

The real challenge is not in achieving scientific discovery itself but translating it into safe and effective medicines. Too often, research stalls during this translational stage.

Collaboration will be central to closing this gap. Product development partnerships such as the Medicines for Malaria Venture (MMV), Drugs for Neglected Diseases initiative (DNDi) and TB Alliance have shown how governments, researchers, industry and non-profit organisations can share risks and expertise in developing new health technologies. They are addressing the important public health needs that commercial markets often overlook.

India is also laying important foundations through initiatives such as the Anusandhan National Research Foundation to promote collaboration between academia, industry and government; the Research Development and Innovation Scheme, which aims to accelerate the translation of research into products; and programmes such as the Promotion of Research and Innovation in Pharma MedTech sector (PRIP) and the National Biopharma SHAKTI Mission, which support industry-led innovation, clinical research capacity and biotechnology infrastructure.

The next step would be to connect these efforts more effectively and ensure that promising discoveries can move through development and reach the patients who need them.

A strong drug discovery and development ecosystem could strengthen the biotechnology sector, attract investment, create high-value jobs and position the country as a global destination for biomedical innovation.

The rewards would extend beyond economic growth to scientific leadership and greater resilience to future health challenges. By building an innovation ecosystem that takes discoveries from the laboratory to the patient, India has the opportunity to demonstrate that world-class biomedical innovation can be both affordable and equitable.

The writer is Continental Lead, Asia, and Director, South Asia, Drugs for Neglected Diseases initiative. Views are personal

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - OCTOBER 5 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Indian team emerges third at International Olympiad



Chennai: India put up a strong show at the 19th International Olympiad on Astronomy and Astrophysics (IOAA) 2026 held in Hanoi, Vietnam, from September 25 to October 5, as all five students who were part of the team bagged medals — 4 gold and 1 silver. A total of 307 students from 64 countries participated in this year's IOAA. In the medals tally, India was placed in the third position jointly with Vietnam, behind Iran and South Korea. Iran and Korea both won 5 golds, the Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education (HBCSE), a National Centre of the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR), Mumbai, said. In all, 51 gold, 48 silver and 60 bronze medals were given out in what was the biggest IOAA till date in terms of number of participants. Since1999, 49 per cent of Indian students have won gold in the event. OUR BUREAU

DPDP Act: Firms pragmatic over registering

IN LIMBO. Data Protection Board yet to be set up; detailed guidelines on the Consent Manager regime are to be published

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As companies work towards the May 2027 deadline of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, a key milestone in the implementation cycle is fast approaching from November 13, 2026, consent managers can apply to the Data Protection Board (DPB) for registration.

However, with just one month to go for this, and the key adjudicating authority — the DPB — yet to be set up and the Board's detailed guidelines on the Consent Manager regime yet to be published, entities are still deliberating whether they would register; their decision is in limbo.

Consent managers are essentially registered, neutral intermediaries that allow individuals to give, manage, review or withdraw consent for their personal data across multiple organisations from a single interface.

This regime has emerged as a new area for privacy tech and data companies to enter, but many of them are still uncertain if they will throw their hat in the ring. The monetisation potential in operating as an intermediary is one such uncertainty, and multiple other aspects remain unclear.

TECH STACK

Currently, software makers providing the tech stack for consent management (the likes of IDfy, Redacto, CAMS and more) are seeing brisk business for their solutions but are still watching for clearer guidelines from the DPB to decide on becoming intermediaries.

Ram Charan Sesharaman, Chief Financial Officer (CFO), CAMS, which has built consent management tech stack ConsenPro, said the response had been encouraging, with over 15 implementations. "Traction in BFSI has been particularly strong, with several capital-market institutions and NBFCs choosing our solution," he added.

Citing industry estimates of DPDP-led tech and compliance spending to be over ₹10,000 crore during the next three years, Sesharaman said consent architecture and governance alone could bring in around ₹1,000 crore (10 per cent). "We will see once the Board sets up clear guidelines, but we'd rather be the technology provider [than the intermediary]," he added.



DIGITAL PERSONAL DATA PROTECTION ACT

- Consent manager registrations open on November 13, but DPB formation still awaited
- Firms hold back as eligibility, monetisation and conflict-of-interest concerns cloud decisions
- Fewer than four in 10 enterprises have mapped their data and third-party handlers, IDfy estimates
- However, DPDP implementation has picked up pace as focus moves from data discovery to building systems
- Government sources say the Board's composition will be announced soon

Malcolm Gomes, COO, IDfy, Head of Privy by IDfy, said Privy is currently engaged with 50-plus live enterprise implementations in banking, insurance, healthcare and retail. He declined to comment on whether IDfy will apply to be consent managers. "DPDP implementation is looking quite different across sectors because the underlying data environments are very different... Right now, fewer than four in 10 enterprises have mapped their data and third parties handling it, and nearly 80 per cent have not yet operationalised DPDP-aligned privacy governance frameworks," Gomes said.

WAITING

Shashank K, Co-founder of AI-powered data privacy and governance platform Redacto, said firms like Redacto are apt to serve in the Consent Manager role. "There will likely be a monetisation roadmap but we are still awaiting clarity on the nuances of who can apply." On the point of conflict, he said tech providers only provide the tech stack to companies and do not directly access the data or process it.

Maulik Bengali, Founder and CEO, IQWorks, said they are actively evaluating applying as their platform has been built particularly for the DPDP Act and Rules, along with the MeitY Electronic Consent Framework. Whether a firm that also serves businesses qualifies [to be an intermediary] will depend on Board's view of each application.

"Tomorrow, it may become a little messy area for us to get into it if any conflict parameters prohibit us from getting involved in selling our consent management tech; so we will wait and decide," another executive said.

STAYING AWAY

Shahana Chatterji, Partner, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co, said there will be short-term operational challenges around how these platforms must operate and what the monetisation models will look like. "There are also strict eligibility criteria and it is likely because of this that we will not see too many entities rushing to seek registration next month."

Industry sources said large consulting firms and law firms may largely stay away from the intermediary role to avoid any business conflicts. Government sources said the formation and composition of the DPB will be announced "soon."

Ahmedabad airport imposes new drop/visit charges on taxis

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Getting dropped off at the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport in Ahmedabad by a taxi will now attract a fee, with the Adani Group-operated airport introducing a "drop-off/visit charge" for taxis and other commercial vehicles entering the terminal area.

The airport has also raised charges for commercial vehicle "pick-ups" by 33.3 per cent, adding to the cost of using taxis to travel to and from the airport.

Taxis and other commercial four-wheelers will be charged ₹50 for drop-off/visit, with the levy going up to ₹200 if the vehicle exceeds the eight-minute limit.

The charges also cover tempos, minibuses and buses, for which the levy can go up to ₹600 for the first 0-30 minutes, adding to the cost of airport travel for passengers using hired transport.

The new charges came into force since October 1. Taxis and other commercial vehicles arriving to pick up passengers will now attract a ₹200 pick-up charge, up from ₹150 earlier — a 33.3 per cent increase.

NO OPTIONS

Auto-rickshaws, meanwhile, are not available for pick-up near the Terminal 1 exit, leaving passengers who want to take an auto to walk out of the terminal area to access one.

On Sunday, passengers were seen walking out of the terminal pick-up zones towards the main road with their luggage and families, apparently to avoid the increased fee.

The airport said the new charges were aimed at managing increasing traffic and supporting the maintenance of its infrastructure.

Patients face financial burden despite free TB medicines, study finds

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Despite free medicines under India's TB control programme, patients with drug-sensitive pulmonary tuberculosis can still face a substantial financial burden, with lost income and the cost of diagnosis accounting for a significant share of their overall expenditure, a systematic review has found.

An analysis of 21 Indian studies published between 2014 and 2024 estimated the average cost of TB care at ₹20,674 per patient. Nearly two-thirds of this, about ₹12,767, was attributed to indirect costs, such as lost wages and reduced productivity, while direct medical expenses averaged ₹6,952.

The study, published in the Indian Journal of Tuberculosis, found that around 15 per cent of households affected by drug-sensitive pulmonary TB incurred catastrophic health expenditure, defined as spending more than 20 per cent of household income on TB care.

Dr Aviraj KS, one of the researchers involved in the meta-analysis, said the findings showed the financial impact of TB.



"Even though the medical cost has reduced, what is hidden or not being seen is the cost beyond the medical treatment, which is the income of the patient, the productivity of the patient," he said.

LOST WAGES

Indirect costs included income lost because patients were unable to work during illness and treatment, as well as reduced productivity.

The study also examined whether the National Tuberculosis Elimination Programme (NTEP), which replaced the earlier Revised National Tuberculosis Control Programme (RNTCP), had reduced the financial burden on patients.

The findings were mixed. Direct medical and non-medical expenditure declined after the introduction of NTEP, suggesting that free medicines and other government support helped reduce some out-of-pocket costs. However, indirect costs, including income lost because of illness and treatment, as well as diagnostic expenditure, increased.

Consequently, the average overall cost of TB care rose slightly from around ₹20,263 before NTEP to ₹21,301 after its introduction.

PRIVATE CARE

Dr Aviraj said one reason patients continue to incur significant expenditure is that many first seek treatment in the private sector, despite the availability of free services through the government programme.

"Although the government is giving free facility and everything, the first approach of the patient is always the private doctor, the private clinicians. There occurs a lot of expenditure," he said.

The financial consequences can extend to the entire household. According to Dr Aviraj, the analysis showed that more than 20 per cent of household income could be spent on TB-related care in some cases.

WIDER SUPPORT

"Government should work before the patient reaches the public healthcare structure," Dr Aviraj said.

He also called for support beyond free diagnostics, medicines and nutritional assistance, including measures to help patients return to work and regain their livelihoods.

"Rehabilitation or self-empowerment of these patients is very, very important," he said.

Data centres emerge as India's job engine

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The data centre ecosystem appears poised to deliver significant job creation in the coming years, despite concerns raised on the ground over employment projections, according to hiring platforms and industry executives.

At a time when global capability centres (GCCs) have cooled their hiring spree and shifted towards a hybrid operating model, data centres are expected to ramp up recruitment across roles.

"The data centre industry is becoming a meaningful employment engine in India, but there is an important distinction between jobs within data centres and those created across the broader ecosystem. Employment needs are not limited to IT professionals. The sector also requires talent in construction, equipment maintenance, power, cooling, telecom and fibre networks, security, facility management, logistics and specialised contracting," said Ganesh S Padmanabhan, Vice-President, Recruitment Business, CIEL HR.

Moreover, if India's planned 9,030 MW data centre pipeline becomes operational by 2030, it could create around 4.33 lakh ecosystem jobs, or roughly 85,000 jobs annually, according to Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital.

HIRING TRENDS

CIEL HR reported more than 7,400 data centre-related job openings in India between October 2025 and September 2026, representing a 14 per cent increase over the previous 12-month period.

"Every megawatt of AI capacity creates significantly more skilled, well-paying jobs than conventional hosting infrastructure, and much of this growth is taking place outside metro cities," said Piyush Somani, Managing Director and Chairman of ESDS.

However, the pace of job creation will ultimately depend on the execution and commissioning of these projects. In Visakhapatnam, for instance, protesters said media reports had mentioned the creation of 1.8 lakh jobs, while Google's assessment report reportedly indicated only 1,200 jobs.

Maneka Gandhi launches vegan pet food brand

Former Minister bets on 'Woofly' to create stable funding stream for animal welfare

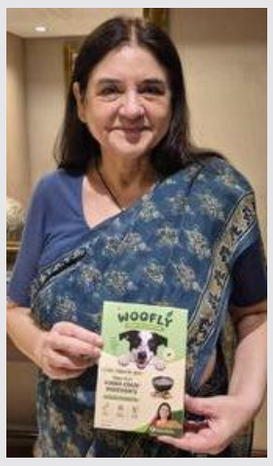
Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Maneka Gandhi is turning to the pet food business to create a source of income for animal welfare that can endure beyond her lifetime, starting with Woofly, a ₹40 per 100 g vegan dog-food brand.

The first offering from the Gandhi-owned Compassion Foods is manufactured at a third-party vegan-only facility in Jaipur.

Gandhi traced the idea back more than four decades. At 23, she used money (₹8 lakh) left to her by her late husband to build an animal shelter and hospital on what was then the outskirts of Delhi. "We didn't even have an architect," she recalled. Built gradually over the years, the facility near Rajouri Garden today spans four acres, employs 130 people, including 11 doctors, and cares for between 4,000 and 5,000 animals.

Now, Gandhi wants to solve a different problem: Funding. For years, animal welfare work was sustained through donations and fundraising initiatives. "But the point is that we can't just do that," she said. "It has to be a steady source of income that does not depend on one-off events."



Maneka Gandhi

That search for recurring revenue led her to pet food. "Something has to be done to sustain it," Gandhi said. "Long term, I want to build more shelters. How do we do that? Where do we get the money from?"

Her answer is Woofly.

FOUR YEARS

Each ₹40 packet contains 100 g of powder that expands to roughly 300 g when mixed with water and can be served with rice. "It's a Maggi noodle concept," Gandhi said.

The formulation was developed at their own cost. "It took us four years of mistakes," she said.

The company is initially targeting pet owners as well as people who regularly feed community dogs. Gandhi is particularly focused on what she calls the "chicken-rice market" individuals, who feed stray dogs rice mixed with inexpensive chicken leftovers.

"This doesn't work for me," she said. "I don't believe that one animal should be fed to another."

Woofly is set to be available through platforms such as Zepto, Amazon and Flipkart, while discussions are underway with Shiprocket for distribution. The brand will also be sold through its own website.

MEOWLY CAT FOOD

Importantly, Gandhi said profits from Compassion Foods will ultimately support People for Animals, the animal welfare organisation she founded. Woofly is only the first step. She plans to expand the portfolio with foods formulated for older and diabetic dogs, followed by Meowly, taurine-fortified vegan cat food.

"Cats have special nutritional requirements; therefore, we are ensuring that Meowly can meet those requirements without the addition of meat or any animal product," she said.

Woofly was unveiled at CINEKIND on World Animal Day, marking the beginning of Gandhi's attempt to turn animal welfare into a self-sustaining enterprise. The real test now is whether enough ₹40 purchases can generate the recurring income that fundraising could not.

ADVERTISEMENT

Breaking down Bharat's targeted MDR framework and what it means for UPI's further evolution



Shri. Ajay Kumar Srivastava, MD & CEO, Indian Overseas Bank

Launched in 2016, the United Payments Interface (UPI) has gained massive mainstream adoption in the decade since. In fact, UPI has an85%share in Bharat's digital payment volume, with more than 241.62 billion transactions processed in FY2025-26 alone. Enabling seamless peer-to-peer (P2P) and peer-to-merchant (P2M) transactions through an interoperable, real-time payments platform, UPI has not only transformed how Bharat transacts, but has also gained recognition as the world's largest real-time payment system by transaction volume. Currently operational in 11 countries, UPI accounts for nearly 49% of global real-time payment transaction volume and continues to bring new users as well as merchants to its ever-expanding ecosystem.

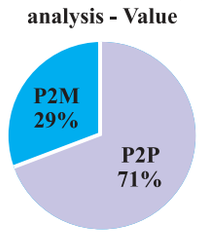
To sustain the pace of innovation however, Bharat is adopting a new Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) framework from 15 October, 2026, where certain transactions will attract a nominal fee that is to be distributed among ecosystem participants.This includes banks, payment service providers and UPI application providers; helping them cover costs incurred towards maintaining fraud/risk controls, customer service, infrastructure upgradation while also enabling payment apps to operate and invest in their businesses moving forward. While this is a clear break away from the previous zero-MDR regime, the merchant-side charge is designed such that the customer continues to access UPI without any fees or hidden charges.

Under the new MDR framework, P2P transactions which account for 71% of the total transaction value will attract a 0% charge. Similarly, P2M transactions below the ₹2,000 threshold and those made by qualifying small merchants will also remain unaffected. However, P2M payments above ₹2,000 will be subject to a 0.4% MDR, with an upper limit capped at ₹300 for transactions above ₹75,000. In the same vein, certain essential/thin-margin sectors such as telecom services, insurance, fuel, utilities, education and agricultural input materials will have a flat ₹5 MDR, thereby reducing the burden on merchants processing such transactions.

According to estimates, this new MDR framework will ensure that 96% of P2M transactions will remain unaffected, a very important fact that needs to be considered when evaluating the likely impact on the merchant ecosystem.A further analysis of UPI transactions further underscores this point. While P2M transactions account for 63% of total transaction volume, it is important to note that 86% of them were driven by small-ticket payments below ₹500. This highlights UPI's extensive use for high-frequency and low-value retail payments, most of which will continue to fall under the zero-MDR category even in the new framework.

P2P transactions on the other hand account for 37% of the total transaction volume, even though they account for 71% of the overall transaction value. These payments will remain unaffected and should see continued usage for higher-ticket transfers between individuals. By keeping P2P transactions out of the MDR ambit, the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has ensured that UPI remains the preferred channel for both retail payments as well as larger-value fund transfers. This measured approach means that the NPCI has taken a large step forwards towards making UPI's business model more sustainable.

UPI P2P and P2M transactions analysis - Value



The strongest argument in favour of the economics of the new MDR framework is that it has introduced a viable revenue stream, without impacting the consumer ecosystem. The MDR revenue generated from larger merchant transactions will be split among key ecosystem participants. This revenue split should help the involved stakeholders in managing remitter risk, help in processing authentication, managing settlement & onboarding as well as ensuring upkeep of the user interface that handles the core payment. Thus, each eligible P2M UPI transaction will ultimately support to improve payment infrastructure in the future.

Introduced after detailed deliberations by the UPI Steering Committee, the new MDR framework will undoubtedly strengthen the long-term sustainability of UPI; even as it keeps payments free for individuals and safeguards small merchants from incurring MDR charges. What's more, it has also been agreed to establish a dedicated fund to promote UPI adoption among small merchants, with an amount equivalent to 5% of total MDR collections being slated to be contributed to this fund. Proceeds will then be used to support wider UPI acceptance, promote sustained usage and include more small businesses in Bharat's digital payments ecosystem.

By monetising the higher-value commercial layer instead of the mass-market microtransaction layer; NPCI has undoubtedly made UPI's payment infrastructure more commercially sustainable. In the best-case scenario, the new MDR framework should generate enough revenue to fund infrastructure upgradation, fraud prevention, enhance network reliability and fuel innovation in the years to come. It could also gradually transition UPI from a public digital payment rail to a broader commercial payments ecosystem that achieves financial self-sustenance and draws greater investments into the network.